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सत्यमेव जयते
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Every moment of whose life symbolises an unwavering commitment to service and national interest, and for whom public welfare is a lifelong mission, under the leadership of such **Seva-Vrati Narendra Modi Ji**, Bharat is experiencing continuous progress, and the entire nation is saying....

12 *Vishwas ke, Vikas ke, Jan-kalyan ke* Saal

» Welfare of the Poor

- » Free monthly ration for 81+ crore people
- » 4+ crore PM Awas houses, 10.5+ crore Ujjwala LPG connections and 12+ crore toilets made life easier

» Women Empowerment

- » 32+ crore Jan Dhan accounts opened for women
- » Permanent commission for women in the armed forces
- » 3+ crore Lakhpati Didis
- » 10 crore rural women empowered through 91+ lakh Self Help Groups

» Nation Building

- » Metro network spanning 1,100+ km across 26 cities
- » 164 Vande Bharat trains running across the country
- » Major infrastructure projects built, including Atal Setu, Sudarshan Setu, Chenab Rail Bridge, Bogibeel Bridge and Pamban Sea Bridge
- » Number of airports increased from 74 to 164

» Youth Empowerment

- » Skill training for nearly 2 crore youth
- » ₹40 lakh crore MUDRA Loan
- » 2.2 lakh startups across the country
- » 10,000+ Atal Tinkering Labs promoting innovation

» Healthcare

- » Free treatment up to ₹5 lakh for senior citizens aged 70+
- » Ayushman Bharat coverage for 60+ crore people
- » Medicines at discounts of up to 90% through 19,000+ Jan Aushadhi Kendras nationwide

» Nation First

- » Record defence exports worth nearly ₹38,400 crore
- » Dream of a Naxal-free India becomes a reality, with a strong crackdown on terrorism
- » Freedom from the colonial mindset – Rajpath became Kartavya Path, and a new Naval Ensign inspired by Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj

» Farmers' Welfare

- » ₹4.3 lakh crore disbursed under PM-KISAN
- » 4+ crore farmers received ₹2 lakh crore crop insurance coverage
- » Crops worth ₹26+ lakh crore procured at MSP
- » Kisan Credit Cards provided to 8 crore farmers

» Middle Class

- » Annual income up to ₹12.75 lakh tax-free
- » Affordable air travel for 1.6+ crore passengers under the UDAN Scheme
- » MBBS seats increased by 151% to nearly 1.3 lakh

» Virasat aur Vikas

- » Construction of the grand Ram Temple in Ayodhya
- » Transformation of Kashi Vishwanath Dham, Mahakal Mahalok and Kedarnath Dham



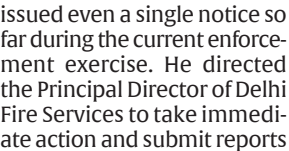
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PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

Chairing a high-level meeting of the Delhi Disaster Management Authority, the Lieutenant Governor reviewed action against unsafe structures, preparedness for future disasters, implementation of the Heat Wave Action Plan,

During the meeting, concern was raised over ongoing illegal construction and violations of fire safety rules in several parts of the city. The LG directed author-

The Lieutenant Governor expressed strong displeasure after being informed that the Delhi Fire Services had not



to the offices of the LG, the Chief Minister, and the Home Minister. Special enforcement teams formed last week, comprising District Magistrates, Deputy Commissioners of

One of the key decisions taken during the meeting was stricter enforcement of Section 32 of the Delhi Fire Services Act, 2007. The proposal, suggested by Home Minister Ashish Sood, was accepted during the meeting. The provision will allow fire prevention and fire safety

In another major proposal, the LG suggested that the Municipal Corporation of Delhi allow citizens to upload photographs of illegal constructions directly through

He instructed officials to remain open to practical suggestions and continuously improve administrative systems to deal with emergencies more effectively.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

According to the inspection report prepared by the Office of the District Magistrate, North District, enforcement teams carried out checks in areas including Siraspur, Hudson Line, GTB Nagar, Vijay

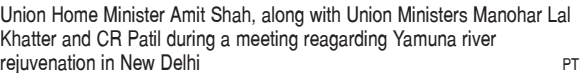
Nagar, Azadpur and Delhi Cantonment. Several establishments were found violating fire safety norms and building regulations, prompting authorities to issue notices, seal premises and

The inspection drive revealed more extensive vio-

Officials inspected Prachi Villa in Hudson Line and found that the hotel, operating in a ground-plus-four-floor building, did not possess a Fire No Objection Certificate, completion certificate or occupancy clearance from the civic authorities. Action under Section 152 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023, was initiated against the property.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

Shah stated that the three states of Haryana, Delhi, and Uttar Pradesh must collectively ensure a standard ecological flow in the Yamuna River. He announced that a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) would be signed between the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) and the National Dairy Development Board



instead be converted into biogas and manure. Shah stated that 129 Sewage Treatment Plants

The Home Minister stated that the desilting of drains discharging into the Yamuna River is proceeding rapidly. Of the 28.57 lakh MT of silt targeted for removal this year, 97 per cent has already been extracted, and the remainder will be removed by June 15. He directed that the silt be utilised in various manufacturing projects to

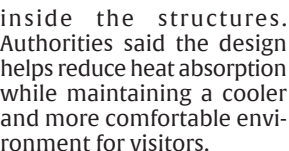
Shah further directed that the construction of industrial Common Effluent Treatment Plants (CETPs) and dairy waste treatment plants must be undertaken with future requirements in mind.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

Two cooling zones are currently operational in Bawana and Alipur in Outer North Delhi, while work has begun on three additional centres, including one near the Deputy Commissioner's office. The project has been

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the government plans to expand the initiative to other parts of Delhi as temperatures continue to rise across the city. She described the cooling zones as reliable relief centres for people exposed to prolonged outdoor heat. The initiative is aimed primarily at helping vulnerable groups such as construction workers, daily-wage labourers, rickshaw pullers, street vendors, drivers, and others who

Officials said the structures have been designed using bamboo to minimise environmental impact while creating sustainable and climate-friendly public spaces. The cooling zones use vetiver grass screens and mist-based cooling systems that naturally lower surrounding temperatures. Natural ventilation systems, including specially designed air circulation passages and exhaust vents, have also been incorporated to improve airflow and reduce heat



vices, including chilled drinking water, ORS packets, seating arrangements, and rest areas. Fire extinguishers and awareness material related to heatwave prevention have also been installed at the sites.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client i.e. ICICI Bank Ltd. that Dharam Singh is the owner of Plot No. 373, are measuring 40 sq. mtrs. in Block "Sector", a Greater Noida. U/s "The said property" by virtue of Transfer deed dated 18.08.2002 has been placed Original Allotment Letter, Original Possession Certificate, Original Lease deed dated 23.04.1991 dated 30.04.2002, Original Transfer cum Sale Deed dt. 30.04.2002, Original Transfer Memorandum, All persons are hereby informed not to deal or carry out any transaction with anyone on the basis of the above missing document. If anyone has already carried out or being carrying out any transaction, kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 7 days of date of present.

Kundan Kumar
209, Indir Nagar,
legals, Indir Nagar, 23, Shivaji Marg, P.O. Nagar, N.Delhi-110 016
209, Indir Nagar,
legals@klnallegals.com Ph: 01141112527-28

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that my client (1) Mr. Aradhana Gambhir, wife of Shri Salil Kumar, and (2) Mr. Salil Kumar, son of Shri. Harivansh Lal Gambhir, both residents of B52-B, Pocket-6, Gangotri Enclave Alaknanda, New Delhi-110019 has lost/imposed the original DDO issued for possession of the land for Water and Electricity in the name of the original allottee in respect of Flat No. 52-B, Pocket-6 (earlier known As Pocket-6), Gangotri Enclave Alaknanda, Kalkaji, New Delhi, and are not traceable. An NCR/FIR has been lodged with the local police vide LR No. 355193/2026 dated 08/06/2026. Any person claiming any right, title or interest, having any objection or found in possession of original document, may write/contact Dy. Director (LABS/FS) or Director

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Shri Vivek Kumar Singh and Smt. Rekha Devi who are co-owners of the Property area measuring 8700 Sq.Ft. comprising Khassa No. 111/19/2, 201, 202/1 and 202/2, 16/1 situated in the revenue estate of Village Nahrli, Tehsil and District Sonapatna, Bihar and call the Public to produce any document having acquired the same vide Sale Deed dated 09/08/2023 duly registered in the of SR-Sonepatna as registration No. 4781, Adat. Book No. 1, dated 09/08/2023 executed by Shri Mukesh Kumar, Sr. Advocate, Sonapatna, Bihar and Shri Vivek Kumar Singh and Rekha Devi intend to mortgage the subject property for the financial assistance from Poonawalla Fincorp Ltd. That, the Original (1) Sale Deed dated 24/06/2011 (docs No. 3843) (2) Sale Deed dated 22/03/2022 (docs No. 1364) (3) Sale Deed dated 09/10/2013 (docs No. 9547) (4) Sale Deed dated 22/03/2022 (docs No. 1364) has been lost/misplaced/not available. To comply

PUBLIC NOTICE
Be it known to all that I, **D. R. Nirmal Kumar Sreeno** s/o Late R. Soren NO 1249, Sector-3, Pocket-1, Vasant Kunj, New Delhi-110070, owner of **DDA Flat NO.6053, 3rd Floor, Sector-D, Pocket-6, Vasant Kunj, New Delhi-110070, The Original Allotment Letter Dated 31/10/2002 and Conveyance Deed Dated 31/08/2005** in respect of said Property, have been lost or misplaced and are not traceable inspite of the best efforts of an FIR/NCR to this effect has been lodged in Crime Branch vide LR. No.352138/2026 dated 07/06/2026.
Any person (s) claiming any rights, interests having any objection, may write/contact with

 **Baba Farid University of Health Sciences**
Faridkot
VACANCIES
Advt No BFU-26/20
 Online applications are invited w.e.f 11/06/2026 to 01/07/2026 from eligible candidates through University website i.e. www.bfuhs.ac.in for the recruitment to the post of Pharmacist (Pharmacy Officer 454) under Department of Health and Family Welfare Punjab. For Application form, fee category wise distribution and other terms & conditions, visit University website www.bfuhs.ac.in.
 Sd/-
Registrar
 RO - 3108/12/2026-27/12109

The image shows the official logo of Delhi Transco Limited, which consists of a stylized 'D' and 'T' inside a circle, with the text 'DELHI TRANS CO LIMITED' around it. Below the logo, the text 'DELHI TRANS CO LIMITED' is written in a large, bold, serif font. Underneath this, the text 'NOTICE INVITING e - TENDER' is written in a bold, sans-serif font. The main body of the notice is in a smaller, sans-serif font, detailing the tender for the renovation of toilet blocks and internal/external finishing work at Shakti Sadan and IP Commercial Office DTL. It provides the tender number T25P131642, the website for downloading the tender details (http://govtprocurement.dtl.gov.in), and the deadline for bid submission (08.07.2026, 13:00 Hrs.).

above named persons at above address/phone no. 9810221449, within 7 days from the date of publication of this notice.

ACHIN SHARMA (ADVOCATE)
(Regd. No. D/5425/2021); G-2/10, Tulsi Tower,
Alaknanda Shopping Complex, New Delhi-110019
Mobile: 9810221449, 9310221449

claim/right/title/interests/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 7 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all the Encumbrances, lien etc.

**N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar
Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110019
Contact # 011-49846316 & 4168732**



BHOPAL MUNICIPAL CORPORATION

Swachh Bharat Mission

Atal Bhavan, 7th Floor, Link road no. 02 Near Tulsi Nagar Bhopal-462003

Ref No.: 44

TENDER NOTICE

Date : 05/06/26

Online bids are invited for following Work. Tender forms may be purchased online by the bidders, having relevant experience.

S. No.	Tender no.	Name of Work	PAC (Rs.)	Cost of Tender form (Rs.)	Earnest money Deposit (Rs.)	Time Period
1	2026_UAD_513428_1	Empanelment of agencies for Hiring of Machines on Rental Basis for Processing of Fresh Municipal Solid Waste at Adampur chhawani waste Processing site Bhopal.	4,72,94,400/-	15,000/-	2,36,472/-	12 months / as per Requirement

Corrigendum and Amendment for above NIT shall not be issued separately in newspapers & correction if any, would be Published on website only.

Executive Engineer (SBM)
Municipal Corporation, Bhopal

T.N. 289/026/027



Pune Municipal Corporation
Deputy Municipal Commissioner,
Solid Waste Management,
Tender Cell



Tender Advt-New Tender.

Tender Sell Period:-	09/06/2026 to 15/06/2026 upto 3:00 PM	Tender Opening date	16/06/2026, 03:00 PM
Tender Submission Period :-	09/06/2026 to 15/06/2026 upto 3:00 PM		

Sr. No.	Tender No.	Work Name	Tender set Amount	Estimate Set (Inclusive of all Taxes)	EMD	Work Period	Contact details
1.	PMC/SWM/2026-27/02	Collection & Transportation of minimum 300MT Per day dry waste coming daily at Ramps/Transfer stations / any other suitable location of PMC and its scientific processing and disposal at Cement Industries for a period of 6 + 3 Months	17,879/-	B 2 tender	3,42,225/-	6 + 3 Months / Till the Completion of tender Amount.	Mr.Vijay Puri 7447472126 Mr.Arjun Mane 9689911533

Note:-

1) All the terms and conditions of this work are included in the tender set vvhich is available on following website: www.mahatenders.gov.in.
All the procedures of tender are carried out through this website only.

2) All the information regarding online tender procedure are available with Tender Cell, Pune Municipal Corporation.

Advt. No.- 03/193
Date- 08/06/2026

Sd/-
Deputy Commissioner
Solid Waste Management
Pune Municipal Corporation



यूनियन बैंक

ऑफ इंडिया



Union Bank

of India

REGIONAL OFFICE - New Delhi, 1, Faiz Road, Jhandewalan,

New Delhi-110005, E-mail : cb8821rec@unionbankofindia.bank

AUCTION NOTICE

For sale of Immovable Properties

FOR FURTHER DETAILS SCAN THE QR CODE



That my Clients Sh. Ashwani Singh Virk S/o Late Shri Jagdish Chander Virk and Mrs. Rashmi Virk W/o Sh. Ashwani Singh Virk, are entering into an Agreement to Sell with said Property Owner Mst. Varsha Nath (aged 74 years), W/o. Late Sh. Amar Nath, towards purchase of her DDA BUILT LIG FLAT BEARING NO. 48, BLOCK: B-2A, SECOND FLOOR, JANAK PURI, NEW DELHI -110058. It is hereby stated that if any individual, firm, company and/or Association has any objection to the said Agreement/sale transaction, may object to the same to the address mentioned hereinbelow within a period of 10 days from the date of this notice. It is also stated that no individual and/or organization shall have any rights, interests or claims whatsoever over the said property, and it is hereby informed that after the execution of the Agreement to Sell/ sale deed, Sh. Ashwani Singh Virk and Mrs. Rashmi Virk shall be the sole and absolute owners of the property mentioned hereinabove, this notice shall be construed as notice to general public:

Advocate P. Mohit Rastogi
Phone No: 9505153153

Office Address: C-30, Lower Ground Floor, Soami Nagar, New Delhi-110817

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable/Movable Assets on **14.07.2026 between 12:00 PM to 05:00 PM (with unlimited extension of 10 minutes each)** under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with Rule 8/ 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rule, 2002 Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged and charged to the Secured Creditor, the possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer of Union Bank of India (secured creditor), will be sold on As is where is". As is what is" and "Whatever there is" on the date mentioned below, for recovery of dues as mentioned hereunder to Union Bank of India from the below mentioned Borrower(s) & Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and the Earnest Money Deposit are also mentioned hereunder

S. No.	Name of the Branch	Name & address of Borrower & Guarantor	Details of Property	Constructive or Physical Possession taken	Total Dues	Reserve Price (in lakh) EMD @ 10% Bid Increment	Name & Contact No. of Authorized Officer
1	CHANDNI CHOWK BRANCH (30710)	1. M/s Noor International Address at : 6112/17, Ramdev Market, Kharibaoli, Delhi-110006 2.Mr. Mohammed Nadeem (Partner & LRS/Legal Heirs) Address at : 1110, Gali Samosan, Farash khana, Delhi-110006 3.Mr. Mohammad Imran (Partner & LRS/Legal Heirs) Address at : 1110, Gali Samosan, Farash khana, Delhi-110006 4.Ms. Nazreen (LRS/Legal Heirs) Address at : 1110, Gali Samosan, Farash khana, Delhi-110006	All that part and parcel of the property consisting of Five Commercial Shops, Property bearing MC no. 173, Ward no. VII, Masjid Tehwar khan Gali, Naya Bans, Chandni chowk, Delhi-110006 Bounded; On the North – Property no. VII/175-176 On the South - Gali On the East – Property no. VII/172(new) On the West - Gali	Physical	Rs. 18.94 lacs + Interest + Expense	93,00,000.00 9,30,000.00 1,00,000.00	Mr. Ajit Kumar Singh (8812006856)

BRIEF TERMS AND CONDITIONS OF E-AUCTION SALE : The sale shall be subject to the Terms & Conditions prescribed in the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002 and to the following further conditions : (1) The Properties are being sold on "AS IS WHERE IS BASIS" and "AS IS WHAT IS BASIS" and " WHATEVER THERE IS BASIS". (2) The particulars of Secured Assets specified in the Schedule herein above stated to the best of the information of the Authorised Officer, but the Authorised Officer shall not be answerable for any error, misstatement or omission in this proclamation. (3) The sale will be done through e-auction platform provided at the Website <https://banknet.com> on date and time of auction specified above. (4) Bank reserves the rights to cancel /postpone the auction at any point of time. (5) For further details and complete Terms & Conditions of the sale, please refer : <http://www.unionbankofindia.co.in/english/TenderViewAllAuction.aspx> (6). Interested person may also contact the concerned authorised officer.

Date: 05.06.2026

Place: New Delhi

Authorized Officer, Union Bank of India

India issues travel advisory for Iran, Israel amid rising tensions

ASHOKE RAJ
■ New Delhi

India on Monday urged its citizens in Israel and Iran to exercise utmost caution, remain vigilant, and avoid all non-essential travel amid the deteriorating security situation in the region following a fresh exchange of hostilities between the two countries.

The advisory comes after Iran launched dozens of missiles toward Israel on Sunday evening in response to Israeli strikes on Beirut's southern suburbs. Following the Iranian attack, Israel reportedly carried out retaliatory strikes targeting central and western Iran, raising fears of a broader regional conflict.

In a statement posted on X, the Embassy of India in Iran reiterated its earlier advisory, urging Indian nationals to refrain from travelling to Iran under the current circumstances.

"In view of the latest developments in the region, the



Embassy reiterates its earlier advice to all Indian nationals to avoid any travel to Iran," the mission said.

The embassy also advised Indians currently residing in Iran to leave the country using available means of transport at the earliest opportunity.

Meanwhile, the Indian Embassy in Tel Aviv issued a similar advisory, calling on Indian nationals in Israel to strictly follow safety guidelines and instructions issued

by Israeli authorities and the Home Front Command.

"In view of the prevailing security situation in the region, all Indian nationals in Israel are advised to exercise utmost caution and remain vigilant at all times," the embassy said.

The mission further urged Indian citizens to remain close to designated shelters and familiarise themselves with the nearest protected spaces near their homes or workplaces. Indians were

also advised to avoid all non-essential travel within Israel until further notice and to closely monitor local news, official announcements, and emergency alerts.

The Indian community in Israel has grown significantly in recent years, with more than 40,000 Indians currently residing across the country. According to official data, approximately 9,000 Indians, including students, were present in Iran when the conflict began on February 28. So far, more than 1,800 Indian nationals have returned home.

To assist citizens in Israel, the Indian Embassy has activated a 24x7 emergency helpline. The mission said it remains in close contact with relevant authorities and will continue to provide updates as the situation evolves.

"The Embassy remains closely engaged with the relevant authorities and will continue to issue updates as necessary," the Indian mission in Tel Aviv said.

Sukhendu Sekhar Ray's exit from TMC shows divisions in INDIA bloc's unity

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Sukhendu Sekhar Ray, a senior leader of the Trinamool Congress (TMC), resigned from both the Rajya Sabha and the party on June 8, 2026. His departure is a major setback for Mamata Banerjee's party and the INDIA bloc. Ray announced his decision at an important opposition meeting in New Delhi, drawing attention to the widening divisions within the anti-BJP alliance after the TMC's heavy loss in the West Bengal Assembly elections, in which the BJP won 207 of 294 seats.

Ray's resignation reduces TMC's Rajya Sabha seats from 13 to 12, creating a vacancy that will lead to a by-election. Although the change in numbers is small, the symbolic impact is important. The INDIA bloc depends on regional partners like the TMC to lead debates and review government bills. Since the NDA already has an advantage, losing even one seat makes it tougher for the opposition to push back or slow down new laws. Analysts say this is the first major parliamentary setback for the TMC after its defeat.

Ray, who helped found the TMC and served as Chief Whip, explained his



reasons for leaving. He pointed to 'anarchical rule,' corruption, crimes against women, and problems in health, education, and law and order. After stepping down, he met with TMC Lok Sabha MPs, sparking rumours that others might also leave. A few days earlier, 58 TMC MLAs had publicly questioned the party's position on the Leader of Opposition role.

This unrest could disrupt the parliamentary group and weaken the bloc's main support in eastern India. The June 8 meeting of 23 parties was meant to show unity after several election losses, but instead revealed serious divisions. Ray's resignation and the DMK's boycott over Congress's alleged 'betrayal' in Tamil Nadu both

show rising tensions. Congress, which leads the bloc, now faces questions about whether it can keep the alliance together. West Bengal, once a stronghold for the INDIA bloc, is now under BJP control.

The TMC's defeat not only gives the BJP a clear win in the state but also hurts the alliance's reputation as a strong national opponent. In the Rajya Sabha, where every vote matters, losing a senior TMC leader at this time could lower morale and reduce the bloc's influence. With the 2029 Lok Sabha elections approaching, this situation will test the alliance's strength. If the TMC splits or loses more ground in Bengal, the opposition could lose an important balance in a state that sends many MPs to parliament.

Ray's resignation is not just an internal TMC matter. Ray's resignation is more than just an issue for the TMC. It is a real test of the INDIA bloc's unity since 2024. The alliance has faced challenges before, but these events reveal a common weakness: if one part fails, the whole group is affected. The result of the Delhi meeting will show whether the bloc can turn its setbacks into new motivation or remain caught in growing divisions and empty promises.

Delhi Government signs pact for smart, dust-free roads

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Monday signed a major agreement with the Central Road Research Institute and the School of Planning and Architecture to introduce a scientific and technology-driven system for road construction, maintenance, and greening across the capital.

The tripartite Memorandum of Agreement was signed under the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta as part of the government's plan to make Delhi's roads safer, cleaner, greener, and more durable. The agreement brings together the Public Works Department, CSIR-Central Road Research Institute, and the School of Planning and Architecture to develop a standard framework for paving, greening, and managing urban roads.

The Chief Minister said the government was not only building roads but creating a complete urban road ecosystem designed for future needs. She said the initiative would help tackle challenges such as traffic pressure, air pollution, and waterlogging through scientific and data-based planning.

The project includes the development of a Road Asset Management System, or RAMS, for the first time in Delhi.



Under the system, roads will be digitally monitored to assess traffic load, structural strength, maintenance needs, and road life. The system will maintain detailed digital records and help authorities identify repair requirements in advance. Officials said the technology-driven mechanism would improve road quality while ensuring better use of public funds through priority-based maintenance planning.

The Government also plans to introduce measures aimed at reducing dust pollution on roads. Scientific green belts will be developed along road-sides, and local plant species will be promoted for landscaping and environmental improvement. Rainwater harvesting systems and improved stormwater drainage networks will also form part of the new framework.

To address monsoon-related flooding, road slopes and drainage systems will be redesigned. Authorities said future pavement designs

would also include features that support groundwater recharge.

The agreement assigns specific roles to the participating institutions. CSIR-CRRI will provide technical expertise related to road engineering, pavement technology, safety standards, and asset management. The School of Planning and Architecture will focus on urban design, streetscape planning, landscaping, and public space development.

PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh described the agreement as a major step towards creating a future-ready road infrastructure system in Delhi. He said the government was developing a data-driven model for road construction and maintenance with the support of leading technical institutions. Singh said the framework would standardise road development, greening, safety measures, and dust-control systems across the capital.

Delhi hotel fire: Main suspect surrenders before court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Jay Mishra, who is a main suspect in the South Delhi hotel fire that killed 22 people, turned himself in to a court on Monday, according to a police official.

Police said Mishra, who is a close associate and accountant of hotel owner Lavkesh Bajaj, also faces an FIR filed in 2024 under section 223 (Causes danger to human life, health, or safety) of the Bharatiya Nyaya

Sanhita. The FIR was filed because the hotel lacked a security system.

Since the fire at Flourish Stays Bed and Breakfast in Malviya Nagar's Hauz Rani area on June 4, investigators had been looking for Mishra. Police teams carried out raids in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar to find him.

Police sources say Mishra has known Bajaj for almost ten years. He has acted as a frontman for several of Bajaj's businesses and managed financial and



accounting work. Investigators think Mishra was important in running the hotel each day. They are now looking into how

involved he was in its management, licensing, finances, and day-to-day decisions.

The Delhi Police continues to expand its investigation

into the tragedy, which is one of the deadliest hotel fires in the capital in recent years. The police had earlier questioned the hotel owner, Bajaj, who is in custody, regarding the property's ownership structure, finances, safety compliance and operational practices.

During questioning, Bajaj reportedly told investigators that he had put Mishra in charge of running the hotel, using documents, financial records, and other business transactions.

Delhi Police to launch AI system for faster emergency routes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Striving for faster movement of ambulances and fire tenders through Delhi roads, the traffic police is implementing an AI-based traffic management and route-mapping system to ensure quicker movement of emergency vehicles during crises, officials said on Monday.

The initiative comes in the wake of several emergencies, especially a recent hotel fire in Malviya Nagar in which 22 people were killed. Some locals had alleged that traffic congestion delayed the arrival of fire tenders at the spot.



"Traffic teams monitor live footage of thousands of CCTV cameras. Besides that, our AI-based traffic management system will give us a clear picture of high traffic zones. In any emergency, in the high traffic zones, our systems will alert fire tenders

and ambulances to take the shortest and fastest routes," a senior police officer said.

He further said that officials from the traffic police and fire departments have explored multiple measures to create traffic-free corridors for emergency vehicles and ensure they reach affected locations in the shortest possible time.

"The objective is to ensure that fire tenders and ambulances are able to move swiftly, even during peak traffic hours. Technology can immediately identify the fastest available route and help emergency vehicles avoid congestion," the officer said.

DTTDC requests MCD for heritage building's blueprints

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Tourism and Transportation Development Corporation (DTTDC) has initiated the survey and is in the process of hiring an agency for the conservation and redevelopment of the 160-year-old Town Hall building in Chandni Chowk.

According to officials, the DTTDC has requested the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) to provide structural blueprints and layout plans of the historic building, which is classified as a Grade-A heritage structure, for its redevelopment into a Global Heritage Centre.

development into a Global Heritage Centre.

The DTTDC's Project Monitoring Unit is preparing a concept plan, detailed drawings, a detailed project report (DPR) and tender documents for the project, officials said.

In a letter to MCD's Deputy Commissioner (City-SP Zone) on June 1, the DTTDC requested the civic body's departments concerned to provide the existing structural blueprints, floor layouts, elevation drawings, maps, and any other relevant historical or technical documents of the town hall premises.

TMC MPs stage a Parliamentary coup

The blow extends beyond West Bengal. It weakens the Opposition's numerical heft in the Parliament and hands the NDA an unexpected psychological victory.

The message from the parliamentary group is clear. Banerjee's authority is now being challenged even in New Delhi. The TMC leadership has not yet responded, but their silence is telling. What started as a problem in West Bengal has now become a national issue. For Banerjee, the fight to save her party has shifted from Kolkata to New Delhi.

Iran steps back, warns Israel of war

Iranian political and military figures had signalled throughout the day that retaliation was likely if Israeli military actions continued.

Hours after the Beirut strikes, Iran launched missiles toward Israel, prompting retaliatory Israeli attacks inside Iranian territory. Israeli authorities stated that one of their targets was a petrochemical facility in southwestern Iran, which they claimed was connected to ballistic missile production.

In response, Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) said it carried out strikes against a comparable facility in the Israeli city of Haifa. Iranian media also reported attacks on two Israeli air bases, while Israel's military announced that it had conducted extensive operations against strategic defense infrastructure inside Iran.

Tensions further intensified as Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei accused the United States of supporting Israel's actions and warned that Washington could share responsibility for any consequences resulting from further escalation.

At the same time, Baghaei indicated that diplomatic communication between Iran and the United States had not been completely severed despite the recent violence.

The regional conflict expanded further when Yemen's Iran-aligned Houthi movement announced plans to prevent Israeli-linked vessels from operating in the Red Sea. The group also claimed responsibility for missile launches aimed at Israel. The Houthis, who control parts of Yemen along a key global shipping route, had largely remained outside the direct confrontation until now.

According to an Israeli military official, Iran fired nearly 30 ballistic missiles toward Israel since Sunday evening, while Houthi forces launched two additional missiles.

Amid growing concerns over a wider regional conflict, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and US President Donald Trump reportedly held a phone conversation on Monday to discuss the situation. Earlier in the day, Trump called for an immediate ceasefire between Israel and Iran, urging both sides to halt military actions and return to diplomatic engagement to prevent further escalation.

ED strikes drugs network across three States

The ED believes this contraband was part of a well-organised syndicate that brought methamphetamine from Myanmar, moved it through the Champhai and Zokhawthar areas of Mizoram, and then delivered it to contacts in Tripura.

The syndicate reportedly used the open Northeastern borders to move large amounts of drugs, taking advantage of the region's tough landscape and closeness to other countries. Investigators think the network was highly organised. Once the methamphetamine entered India through Mizoram, it was sent south to Tripura for further distribution, possibly into Bangladesh or within India. The ED has also found that the money made from this illegal trade, totalling ₹142 crore, was moved through many bank accounts and shell companies to hide its origin. These financial moves were meant to hide the source of the money and make it look legal. The raids on Monday are focused on collecting documents, financial records, digital data, and

other evidence to trace the money and find those involved. ED teams are checking bank transactions, property papers, and communication records at the locations they searched. Sources say the operation is still underway, and more information will be shared soon.

This case shows the growing link between drug trafficking and money laundering in north-eastern India. The area, which shares long, open borders with Myanmar and Bangladesh, has often seen drugs coming in from the Golden Triangle. In recent years, methamphetamine has become a high-value drug, taking the place of opium and heroin on some smuggling routes. Officials say the agency will now look into the syndicate's full financial network, including hawala operators, fake accounts, and front companies. The ED can also seize properties and assets gained from crime under the PMLA.

The investigation is also expected to improve teamwork between the ED and NCB in fighting narcofinancing. This comes as security agencies increase their watch along the northeastern borders due to growing worries about drug smuggling. Authorities think breaking the financial support for these groups is just as important as stopping the drugs themselves. More arrests and property seizures are likely as officials finish reviewing the seized evidence.

Waitlist gets a crystal ball: Railways to unveil...

Today, the system has become so popular that most people no longer approach ticket counters. Currently, nearly 88 per cent of total ticketing demand in the country is fulfilled through online channels.

The RailOne mobile app is rapidly gaining popularity among passengers. It was launched in July last year. In less than a year, it has recorded over 3.5 crore downloads across the country.

One of the biggest reasons for its popularity is that the app not only provides all railway-related information to the common man but also resolves complaints related to ticketing and other services.

Eight killed in Vizag steel plant mishap

Likewise, Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu said the steel plant accident left him deeply shocked.

"I am distressed to learn that several workers have lost their lives in this accident. I have spoken to the concerned officials and directed them to undertake relief measures in coordination with all Government departments," said Naidu in a post on X. Visakhapatnam district collector M Abhishikh Kishore said the accident occurred at 4.15 pm on Monday.

He observed that the six injured workers were shifted to two private hospitals in the port city.

According to the police, molten iron spilt while being moved in a bucket by a crane. Police said the molten iron was extremely hot at about 1,600 degrees Celsius.

Opposition leaders rally to rebuild unity

Rahul Gandhi had in August last year hosted opposition leaders at his residence that brought together nearly 50 leaders from over 25 opposition parties.

Opposition leaders decided to write to the chief justice of India on the SIR exercise and 'vote loot', besides demanding the immediate resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the NEET-CBSE row.

Flanked by Rahul Gandhi, Akhilesh Yadav, Mamata Banerjee and other senior leaders of the grouping at a Press conference later, Kharage said, "We have agreed on five issues. A letter would be sent to the chief justice of India (CJI) soon on the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, 'vote loot' and 'stealing of elections'.

The opposition leaders also decided to continue coordination during the upcoming Monsoon Session of Parliament, with daily morning meetings at the office of the leader of opposition.

The leaders began the deliberations to help forge unity and rework their strategy to take on

the BJP, while ironing out differences within after the defeat of regional outfits Trinamool Congress and DMK in the recent Assembly polls in West Bengal and Tamil Nadu, respectively.

Talking to media in Mumbai Shiv Sena (UBT) Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Raut insisted that the Opposition grouping should declare a prime ministerial face for the 2029 Lok Sabha polls.

"We have to face the 2029 Lok Sabha polls by projecting a prime ministerial candidate of the INDIA bloc. This has been (Shiv Sena UBT chief) Uddhav Thackeray's stand," Raut told reporters in Mumbai.

Government showcases welfare push as it turns...

Modi said through the Direct Benefit Transfer and digital platforms, support is reaching people directly and transparently.

"This has reduced leakages, improved efficiency and strengthened trust in governance. This is how the journey of furthering 'Garib Kalyan' has become a collective movement towards human empowerment and realising our dream of a Viksit Bharat," he said.

In a series of posts on social media, the Prime Minister shared:

"Over the last 12 years, India has witnessed many transformations and at the core of these changes is the welfare of the poor and downtrodden. We have always been inspired by Antyodaya and our effort has always been to ensure that the benefits of development reach those who were left behind for decades.

From Jan Dhan accounts and Direct Benefit Transfer to Swachh Bharat, PM Awas Yojana, Jal Jeevan Mission, Ayushman Bharat and more, every initiative has been driven by a simple objective of ensuring people have dignity and opportunity. #12YearsOfGaribKalyan"

Modi was sworn-in as prime minister for the third consecutive time on June 9, 2024, following another decisive victory in the 2024 Parliamentary elections. He took oath as prime minister for the first time on May 26, 2014. His second term began on May 30, 2019.

Congress slams Bhupender Yadav for poaching TMC MPs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress on Monday took a swipe at Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav over the raging political turbulence in the TMC, saying he has spent the day poaching when his special job is to nab poachers and prevent poaching, and not be one himself.

The Opposition party's attack came after reports surfaced that around a dozen dissident TMC MPs gathered at the Motilal Nehru Marg residence of Union minister and BJP's West Bengal election in-charge Bhupender Yadav.

Congress general secretary in-charge communications, Jairam Ramesh, said, "The Union Minister of Environment, Forests, and



Climate Change, who looked after elections in West Bengal, has spent the day poaching."

"This minister's special job is to nab poachers and prevent poaching and not be one himself," Ramesh said, taking a dig at Yadav.

The simmering rebellion

within the TMC appeared to gather fresh momentum on Monday, with rebel leader Ritabrata Banerjee portraying veteran Rajya Sabha MP Sukhendu Shekhar Ray's resignation from the party and the Upper House as a sign of widening dissent against the official leadership. While TMC

supremo Mamata Banerjee, national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee and several senior MPs attended a meeting of the INDIA bloc leaders, reports surfaced of around a dozen dissident TMC MPs gathering at the Motilal Nehru Marg residence of Union minister and BJP's West Bengal election in-charge Bhupender Yadav.

The meeting, viewed by many as a sign that the revolt within the party's legislative ranks is now spilling into the Parliament, was attended by Ray.

The crisis engulfing the TMC deepened as 20 Lok Sabha MPs, led by Chief Whip Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar, decided to write to Speaker Om Birla declaring support for the BJP-led NDA.

RS polls: Cross-voting fear in MP, Jharkhand

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Cross-voting is expected in the June 18 Rajya Sabha elections in Jharkhand and Madhya Pradesh, where an interesting contest has unfolded with the entry of BJP-backed candidates, as the NDA inches towards a two-thirds majority in the Upper House.

While the BJP fielded Mahesh Kewat against Meenakshi Natarajan of the Congress for the third seat in Madhya Pradesh, it has backed Parimal Nathwani for the second seat in Jharkhand against Congress's Pranav Jha.

A total of 28 candidates are in the fray for 26 seats in 12 states across the country, with direct con-



tests in Jharkhand and Madhya Pradesh.

The Election Commission announced to hold the elections on June 18 following the retirement of the incumbents, including former prime minister HD Deve Gowda, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and party leader Digvijaya Singh, and two Union ministers, Ravneet Singh Bittu and George Kurian.

IAF to use Mi-17 to secure NEET paper

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As the Government is set to conduct the NEET-UG re-test on June 21, it has taken some measures to ensure security, including the deployment of Mi-17 helicopters of the IAF for the secure delivery of question papers to various locations across the nation.

Ahead of the re-examination, question paper setters, moderators, and translators have been moved to a secure, undisclosed facility, where they will remain under lockdown until the examination is conducted. Access to mobile phones, laptops, internet services and all forms of external communication has been heavily restricted to eliminate any possibility of a paper leak as part of the large security cover. As regards the



deployment of the Mi-17 helicopters, sources said the IAF will use them and other assets to transport question paper packets from 18 locations. The move is part of enhanced security measures to ensure a leak-free examination.

The IAF will provide logistical support for the NEET-UG 2026 re-examination on June 21, with Mi-17 helicopters and other air assets ferrying confidential question paper packets from 18 designated locations to distribution centres and examination hubs nationwide, secure delivery.

West Bengal Government restores full CBI authority

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Kolkata

The West Bengal Government has officially given back full authority to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) across the State. On Monday, the State issued a notification under Section 6 of the Delhi Special Police Establishment (DSPE) Act, 1946, allowing the CBI to operate throughout West Bengal.

Now, the CBI can investigate all offences listed under Section 3 of the Act, primarily corruption and economic crimes, as well as central cases that previously required separate approval. Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari said this decision brings back powers that the earlier Trinamool Congress Government had taken away. The TMC withdrew general consent on November 16, 2018, claiming the central agency was being



'misused'. After that, the CBI needed special permission for each investigation, which slowed down probes into major scams, recruitment issues, and cooperative-sector fraud. Since the BJP won the 2026 Assembly election, Adhikari's Government has taken a strong stand against corruption.

In mid-May, the Government approved sanctions under the Prevention of Corruption Act in some pending cases, allowing the CBI to file charge sheets

against nine officials. Monday's notification goes further by giving the agency full authority to work in the State. Legal experts say Section 6 consent matters because, without it, CBI officers do not have police powers in West Bengal.

This also affects ongoing investigations ordered by the Supreme Court or the Calcutta High Court. Restoring CBI powers now puts West Bengal in line with most other states that allow general consent,

showing a move toward more cooperation between institutions. This decision is important both symbolically and practically. It responds to public worries about corruption under the previous Government.

Investigations that were delayed for years can now move forward faster. Critics of the old Government say the withdrawal of consent was meant to protect politically connected officials. The new order removes that obstacle. The decision also sends a clear political message: the era of selective federalism has ended.

By restoring the CBI's mandate, Chief Minister Adhikari is focusing on accountability. In a state with a history of recruitment scams and governance issues, this move could help solve many old cases and rebuild public trust in investigations.

Brinda Karat slams Delhi Police for allegedly harassing a woman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Senior Communist Party of India (Marxist) leader and former Rajya Sabha MP Brinda Karat on Monday shot off a letter to Delhi Police Commissioner Satish Golchha, seeking his urgent intervention over the alleged illegal detention, interrogation, and surveillance of a young woman by personnel of the New Rajinder Nagar police station.

Terming the incident an extraordinary misuse of police authority, Karat alleged that the postgraduate student, Aahana Singh Kaith, was subjected to "totally illegal and inhuman harassment" to prevent her from participating in a political demonstration.

According to the letter released by the CPI(M) Central Committee, the victim was cornered at a local gym on June 5 by a



group of police personnel, including an officer identified as Shivam and a woman Sub-Inspector named Rita. They allegedly took her to a nearby parking area, where she was subjected to intense questioning regarding her family background, political leanings, and her plans regarding a demonstration organised by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) the following day.

"She was threatened to become a police informer on the threat of action against her," Karat wrote, adding that the personnel forcibly checked the woman's

mobile phone and WhatsApp messages without a court warrant, violating her fundamental right to privacy.

The CPI(M) leader further alleged that the harassment escalated when a police official was deployed outside the student's flat as a personal security officer (PSO) to monitor her movements. The victim was allegedly ordered to stay indoors and share her live location with the police station if she stepped out.

Karat stated that she personally intervened by telephoning the deployed police personnel, who admitted to acting on direct orders from the New Rajinder Nagar police station. "A young woman is picked up by predominantly male police without any warrant, her privacy violated, and she is placed under surveillance and virtual house arrest without any charges.

Post-result services portal fully functional: CBSE

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) on Monday said its post-result services portal was fully functional during the notified application period and more than 1.6 lakh candidates successfully submitted requests for over 3.8 lakh answer books.

In a statement on social media, the board said the application window for verification and re-evaluation was fully functional throughout the notified period, June 2-7, under the supervision of Government technical agencies and teams from the IITs.

"During the above application period, more than 1.6 lakh candidates successfully submitted requests pertaining to over 3.8 lakh answer books, reflecting the extensive utilisation of the services by the candidates," the CBSE said.

The board said the system remained under monitoring by cybersecurity teams throughout the operational period to prevent malicious traffic and cyber threats. It also said CBSE teams provided support to students through its helpdesk and grievance redressal channels. The clarification came amid certain media reports and social media posts regarding the functioning of the



Post-Result Services Portal.

Addressing concerns raised by some students and parents, CBSE said the message "Roll Number Not Found" was displayed only when a candidate had not successfully applied during the first phase of the post-result services process — the Answer Books Photocopy Application Window.

"CBSE has taken note of certain media reports and social media posts regarding the functioning of the Post-Result Services Portal. To clarify doubts of some of these students and parents, it is informed that the message 'Roll

Number Not Found' is displayed when a candidate had not successfully applied during the first phase of the Post-Result Services process, namely the Answer Books Photocopy Application Window," the board said.

"As clearly outlined earlier, only those candidates who had applied for their scanned answer books during the preceding stage (Answer Books Photocopy) were eligible to avail the subsequent stage of Verification of Issues Observed and Re-evaluation of Answers," the board said.

NMCG launches citizen guide to protect urban wetlands

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Seeking to boost community participation in wetland conservation, the National Mission for Clean Ganga (NMCG) on Monday shared a step-by-step guide for citizens to revive and protect urban wetlands under its "wetland mitra" initiative.

In a post on social media, the mission said citizens can contribute by becoming "wetland mitras" by identifying nearby lakes, ponds and wetlands, documenting their condition through photographs over time and formally associating themselves with local restoration efforts.

The mission also shared a six-step model for wetland restoration.

"Reviving a dead lake is not some magic trick. It is just a straightforward path of six steps," it said in the post.

Major Bhargav Kalita awarded Shaurya Chakra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Major Bhargav Kalita of The Kumaon Regiment, currently serving with the 50th Battalion of the Rashtriya Rifles, has been awarded the Shaurya Chakra, one of India's highest peacetime gallantry awards, in recognition of his exceptional courage and outstanding leadership in counter-terrorism operations.

Hailing from Assam, Major Kalita has been a pivotal figure in maintaining peace and security in conflict-ridden zones. Since October 2022, the officer has actively participated in multiple successful operations, resulting in the neutralisation of three dreaded terrorists and the apprehension of four hardcore Over Ground Workers (OGWs).

The pinnacle of his targeted operations came on December 2, 2024, when Major Kalita meticulously planned



and executed a surgical ambush based on short-notice intelligence inputs. Displaying supreme tactical acumen, he positioned his team to achieve complete surprise, waiting patiently for the target to enter the designated killing ground. When challenged at close quarters, the holed-up terrorist opened indiscriminate fire in a desperate bid to escape. Undeterred by the incoming volley of bullets, Major Kalita brought down precise fire and skillfully manoeuvred his team to block all possible escape routes, pinning the insurgent down.

5,300 Indian SIMs used from Cambodia for cyber frauds; ED begins probe

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate has started probing a case involving the alleged purchase of 5,300 SIM cards in the country, which were used in Cambodia by a Malaysian national-led gang to perpetrate cyber frauds across India, duping people for hundreds of crores of rupees.

The central agency had raided 7 premises in Rajasthan's Kishangarh (Ajmer), Nagaur and Jodhpur apart from Ludhiana in Punjab on June 5, leading to the identification of 30 domestic bank accounts that are allegedly part of this fraud network. The ED case, filed under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), stems from a Jodhpur Police (Cyber



Wing) FIR against certain POS (point of sales) vendors who "fraudulently" activated Indian SIMs and handed them over to a Malaysian national who operated them from Cambodia, the ED said in a statement issued on Monday.

Several cyber crime incidents, including digital arrests, have been detected against Indians from

"scam farms" located in Cambodia.

The ED said it analysed 2.3 lakh numbers (SIM cards) and it was found that about 36,000 of them were active in Cambodia, out of which nearly 5,300 were involved in committing cyber frauds across India to the tune of hundreds of crores of rupees by making WhatsApp calls. During the searches, it was

Nation Focus



PM LAUDS ARMENIAN LEADER PASHINYAN ON ELECTION WIN

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday congratulated Armenian leader Nikol Pashinyan on the victory of his Civil Contract Party in the country's parliamentary elections and said he was looking forward to working closely with him. Armenian Prime Minister Pashinyan on Monday claimed victory in a general election as preliminary results showed his governing Civil Contract Party came first with 49.81 per cent of the vote. "Congratulations to Nikol Pashinyan on the impressive victory of the Civil Contract Party in the parliamentary elections. The renewed mandate reflects the enduring trust and confidence of the people of Armenia in your leadership and vision. I look forward to working closely with you to further deepen the warm and historic ties of friendship and cooperation between India and Armenia," Modi said in a post on social media. (PTI)



IAF AIRLIFTS 5 CRITICALLY ILL PATIENTS FROM LADAKH

Five critically ill patients, including three personnel of the Indian Army, have been airlifted from Ladakh to Chandigarh for advanced medical care, IAF said on Monday. In a post on social media, the Western Air Command of the Indian Air Force also said 143 lives have been saved through casualty evacuation operations in the Ladakh sector alone during 2026. The WAC shared details about the critical medical evacuation mission undertaken from Ladakh, despite challenging high-altitude terrain and inclement weather conditions. "The Indian Air Force successfully undertook a critical Medical Evacuation mission from Ladakh, airlifting five Dangerous Ill Listed patients for advanced medical care at Chandigarh. (PTI)

₹5.38 crore hydroponic weed seized at IGI Airport, 2 held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Customs officials at Indira Gandhi International (IGI) Airport foiled a major narcotics smuggling attempt, seizing 15.38 kg of hydroponic weed valued at approximately ₹5.38 crore from two passengers who arrived from Kuala Lumpur, officials said on Monday.

Customs officers intercepted the two passengers after they crossed the Green Channel upon arrival on AirAsia X flight D7-182 on June 7. Acting on specific intelligence and passenger profiling, officers subjected the travellers to detailed scrutiny.

During the examination, officials noticed that the passengers were carrying two brand-new geysers in addition to their checked-in baggage. Suspicion deepened after sustained questioning and scrutiny of communications on their mobile phones.

The geysers were subsequently subjected to X-ray screening, which revealed concealed material inside the appliances. On dismantling the units, Customs officers uncovered a sophisticated concealment mechanism and recovered 145 vacuum-sealed packets hidden within the geysers.

The packets contained a green leafy substance suspected to be hydroponic weed, a high-potency variety of cannabis. The total weight of the seized contraband was 15.38 kg.

Customs officials estimated the illicit market value of the narcotics at around ₹5.38 crore.



States Focus



BJP IS ANTI-PEOPLE, WILL BE REJECTED: SUDHAKAR

Telangana Congress spokesperson Bandi Sudhakar Goud launched a scathing attack on the BJP, stating that its anti-people policies will lead to the party being completely rejected and chased away by the public. Speaking to the media, Bandi Sudhakar Goud strongly condemned the statements made by BJP State President Ramchander, who compared the current Congress-led Praja Palana in Telangana to the tyrannical Razakar rule. He termed such comparisons as completely foolish and ignorant of history. "The Congress Party has a glorious history. It brought independence to this nation, actively participated in the Telangana peasant armed struggle, and fulfilled the decades-long dream of Statehood. It is the party that sacrificed its top leaders for the integrity of India," Goud remarked. Mocking the BJP's current political status in the State, the TPCC spokesperson pointed out that the saffron party lost its deposits in 111 Assembly constituencies in Telangana. (PNS)



SUKHU OPENS FIRST WOMEN'S DE-ADDICTION CENTRE IN SHIMLA

Young people who fall victim to drug addiction are not criminals, said Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu on Monday, inaugurating the first women's de-Addiction and rehabilitation centre in Shimla. He said that the growing problem of drug abuse in Himachal Pradesh, particularly the use of chitta (heroin), was not merely a law-and-order issue but a serious social, family and humanitarian challenge. In a statement issued here, Sukhu said that the State Government was addressing the problem at an early stage by creating public awareness and taking strict action against drug traffickers. (PTI)

Sukhendu's resignation signals bigger TMC split: Ritabrata

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata

The simmering rebellion within the TMC appeared to gather fresh momentum on Monday, with rebel leader Ritabrata Banerjee portraying veteran Rajya Sabha MP Sukhendu Shekhar Ray's resignation from the party and the Upper House as a sign of widening dissent against the official leadership.

Banerjee, who now heads the breakaway faction in the West Bengal Assembly, described Ray's departure as more than an individual act of protest, calling it a "unity of will" among a section of dissatisfied leaders within the party.

Ritabrata, who was recognised as the leader of opposition in the Assembly by Speaker Rathindra Bose after securing the support of 58 of the TMC's 80 MLAs, said he expected more parliamentarians to publicly distance themselves from the



party in the coming days.

His remarks came amid contrasting political scenes unfolding in New Delhi.

While TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee, national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee and several senior MPs attended a meeting of the INDIA bloc leaders, reports surfaced of around a dozen dissident TMC MPs gathering at the Motilal Nehru Marg residence of Union minister and BJP's West Bengal election in-charge Bhupender Yadav.

The meeting, viewed by

many as a sign that the revolt within the party's legislative ranks is now spilling into Parliament, was attended by Ray.

Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, who is in the national capital on official work, and former Tripura chief minister Biplab Deb, the BJP's former co-in-charge for the recently concluded West Bengal elections, reportedly also paid a brief visit to Yadav's residence.

Against this backdrop, Ritabrata suggested that Ray's resignation was only the beginning of a larger political

realignment. "Ray is a senior leader, and his resignation marks the unity of will among us and a significant section of party leaders who are outside the State Assembly.

Kolkata's distance from Delhi is barely 1,435 km, and the number of disillusioned TMC parliamentarians is very likely to go up. That development can happen with each passing hour from now," he told reporters outside the Assembly.

He added that he was in touch with several MPs who share similar grievances.

Although Banerjee said he had not spoken to Ray before the latter took the decision to resign, he expressed complete agreement with the veteran parliamentarian's criticism of the party's internal functioning.

According to him, concerns about dissenting voices being ignored and frustrations over the party's conduct in the Rajya Sabha are not isolated sentiments.

Assam CM allocates portfolios to 12 newly inducted ministers

TONY DAS
Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Monday allocated portfolios to 12 newly inducted ministers.

The chief minister retained Home and Political, PWD, Power, Information and Public Relations, and departments not allotted to any other minister.

He made the announcements in a social media post.

Among the senior ministers, Ranoj Pegu retained the Education Department, Ashok Singhal has been allocated his previous Health & Family Welfare, and Medical Education & Research, while Bimal Borah has been given Cultural Affairs and



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma during a meeting at Lok Sewa Bhawan on Monday

PIONEER PHOTO

Industries, Commerce & Public Enterprises, and Act East Policy Affairs.

Pegu has also been given the responsibility of Tribal Affairs (Plains) and Information Technology.

The Finance Ministry has been given to Sarma's close

associate Jayanta Malla Baruah, along with the Environment and Forest, and Mines and Minerals departments. "With the approval of the Hon'ble Governor of Assam, I am pleased to announce the allocation of portfolios amongst the

members of the Council of Ministers of the Government of Assam," Sarma posted on X. The 12 ministers were sworn in on June 5, while four other ministers were administered the oath of office on May 12 along with the chief minister.

The portfolios of the four ministers were announced earlier.

Former speaker Biswajit Daimary, who was also inducted into the ministry, has been allocated Handloom, Textiles & Sericulture, Sports and Youth Welfare; Skill, Employment and Entrepreneurship; and Indigenous, Tribal Faith and Culture departments.

AGP's Keshab Mahanta, a minister in the NDA govern-

ment since 2016, has been allocated Revenue & Disaster Management, Science, Technology and Climate Change, and General Administration portfolios.

Pijush Hazarika, a close associate of Sarma since his Congress days, has been given Agriculture, Irrigation and Parliamentary Affairs.

Kaushik Rai, also a minister in the previous Government, has been given the responsibility of Food, Public Distribution and Consumer Affairs; Housing and Urban Affairs, and Cooperation departments.

Krishnendu Paul has been allocated the Public Health Engineering, Hill Areas and Barak Valley Development portfolios.

INDIA bloc meet soon to iron out differences: Sharad Pawar



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Pune

Amid reports that the DMK is distancing itself from the INDIA alliance, NCP (SP) chief Sharad Pawar said on Monday that a meeting of key leaders of the Opposition bloc would be convened soon to resolve differences.

Speaking to reporters in Baramati, Pawar said INDIA (Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance) partners are holding a review meeting in Delhi during the day, where an appeal will be made to all constituents of the bloc not to take any extreme step.

"In the recent elections, the INDIA bloc partners contested together in some places and separately in others. After the elections, the DMK, one of the constituents of the alliance, has been indicating that it may walk out.

"Since such a situation is emerging, we will, in the next eight to 15 days, invite the key leaders (of the grouping) and try to find a solution. I am sure a solution will be found," he said.

Pawar said Monday's meeting in Delhi is primarily a review meeting. "An appeal will be made that no one should take any extreme step," he added. He said NCP (SP) working president Supriya Sule would represent the party at the meeting in the national Capital.

BJP eyes sweep in Gujarat RS elections

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Ahmedabad

All four BJP candidates on Monday filed their nomination papers for the upcoming Rajya Sabha elections from Gujarat, and with Congress not contesting, their victory looks certain as of now.

With the term of Shaktisinh Gohil ending later this month, the Congress will not have any representative from Gujarat in the upper house of the Parliament. The four Rajya Sabha seats from Gujarat are falling vacant as the six-year terms of sitting MPs Rambhai Mokariya, Narhari Amin, and Ramilaben Bara (all from BJP), and Shaktisinh Gohil of Congress are ending on June 21. Gohil is the lone Congress member from Gujarat in the Rajya Sabha.

Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel, Deputy CM Harsh Sanghvi, ministers, state BJP president Jagdish Vishwakarma and other senior leaders of the party were present when Rajubhai



Gujarat Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghvi and others during a meeting, in Ahmedabad, Gujarat

PTI

Shukla, Mansinh Parmar, Mukeshbhai Rathwa and Jitendra Kanjariya submitted their nomination papers at the assembly complex in Gandhinagar.

Shukla, 62, is currently in charge of the BJP's Surendranagar district unit.

He had earlier served as president of the Kadi municipality and general secretary of the Mehsana district BJP. Tribal leader from Chhotaudepur district, Rathwa (39), currently serves as the general secretary of the BJP's district unit. Earlier,

he was the vice president of the BJP's youth wing.

Parmar, 45, who hails from Gir Somnath district, is the BJP OBC Morcha's Gujarat unit president.

Another prominent OBC leader, Kanjariya (39), hails from Devbhumi Dwarka district. He had earlier served as a member of a district panchayat executive committee. With the BJP having 161 MLAs in the 182-member Legislative Assembly and the Congress not fielding a candidate, the ruling party is set to win all four seats unopposed.

A day before filing nominations, the BJP candidates held a meeting with party MLAs in Gandhinagar on Sunday to ensure coordination. The scrutiny of nomination papers will take place on June 9, and June 11 is the last date for withdrawal of candidature. If more than one candidate remains in the fray for any seat, polling will be held on June 18, and counting will take place the same day.

Rural tap water coverage crosses 81%, reaches 15.8 cr homes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Rural tap water coverage in the country has risen from 3.23 crore households in August 2019 to 15.84 crore households by May 2026, covering 81.87 per cent of the country's 19.35 crore rural households, according to a Government document released on Monday.

The document, issued as part of the BJP-led Central Government marking 12 years in office, said the increase was achieved under the Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM), launched in 2019 to provide potable water through functional household tap connections to every rural household.

According to the document, budgetary allocations for the mission increased by 488 per cent between 2020-21 and 2026-27 to ₹67,670 crore.

The Government said that



2.77 lakh villages have achieved 100 per cent tap water coverage under the Har Ghar Jal campaign.

Household tap water coverage in aspirational districts increased from 23.62 lakh in August 2019 to 2.20 crore by May 2026, while 1.11 crore households in aspirational blocks had tap water connections by the same

date. The number of schools with tap water connectivity increased from 29,711 in August 2019 to 9.23 lakh by May 2026, while coverage in anganwadi centres, it went up from 15,464 to 9.66 lakh during the period.

Tap water connectivity in gram panchayats and community health centres reached 3.93 lakh institu-

tions, covering 77.27 per cent of such facilities, the document said.

According to the document, improved access to clean drinking water has reduced waterborne diseases, strengthened sanitation and supported better educational outcomes, particularly for children and adolescent girls.

The document also highlighted the progress of the Swachh Bharat Mission (Grameen), launched in October 2014 to address inadequate sanitation facilities in rural India, where around 550 million people lacked access to such facilities at the time.

According to the Government, budgetary allocations for the mission increased by 83 per cent from ₹3,929 crore in 2014-15 to ₹7,192 crore in 2026-27. Over 12.11 crore individual household toilets have been constructed under the pro-

gramme so far. During Phase I of the mission, sanitation coverage increased from 39 per cent in 2014 to 100 per cent in 2019, following which India was declared Open Defecation Free (ODF).

As of March 2026, over 5 lakh villages have attained ODF Plus (Model) status.

According to the document, ODF Plus includes comprehensive village cleanliness through solid and liquid waste management systems in rural India.

The document said solid waste management systems are active in 5.31 lakh villages, while liquid and greywater management systems are operational in 5.50 lakh villages. In addition, 2,415 plastic waste management units have been established across 5,482 blocks.

It said the achievement of the Swachh Bharat Mission has been associated with a significant decline in morbidity and mortality.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Bengaluru

The ruling Congress in Karnataka on Monday took a dig at the BJP, accusing the party of denying a Rajya Sabha nomination to JD (S) patriarch and former Prime Minister HD Deve Gowda from the State for a subsequent term.

The grand old party also claimed that the BJP insulted the people of Karnataka by denying Gowda the Rajya Sabha nomination.

Late on Sunday, the BJP announced Professor M Nagaraj as its Rajya Sabha candidate from Karnataka, where the party can win one of the four seats going to polls on June 18, based on its current strength in the Assembly.

The polls were necessary because four MPs, including Gowda, are retiring later this month. The JD (S), an ally of the BJP, was reportedly



hoping the latter would renominate its supremo to the Rajya Sabha.

"Yesterday in the dead of the night, the BJP denied a Rajya Sabha nomination to former Prime Minister, HD Deve Gowda, deciding to choose its State Vice President Incharge of District Building Construction, M Nagaraja, over Ex PM," senior party leader and Congress in-charge of Karnataka, Randeep Singh Surjewala posted on 'X'.

"The constant humiliation heaped upon JD (S) by BJP and its leadership and its repeated acceptance by HD Kumaraswamy merely for

sticking to a ministerial chair at any cost is highly astonishing and eye-opening. Furthermore, accepting this insult is an absolute extreme," he said.

Kumaraswamy is the son of Deve Gowda and a Union Minister for Heavy Industries.

Pointing out that in the May 2019 General Elections, BJP's GS Basavaraju had defeated Deve Gowda in Tumakuru Lok Sabha segment, the AICC leader said that the Congress and its leader Sonia Gandhi, despite their political differences and respecting his status as former PM who hailed from Karnataka, extended support to elect Gowda to the upper house.

"In fact, Gowda had earlier said and maintained his strong opposition to the BJP, going to the extent of publicly stating that he would disown Kumaraswamy if he joined hands with the BJP," he said.

Thousands of people take out rally demanding NRC updaten in Manipur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Imphal

Thousands of people took out a rally demanding NRC updaten in Manipur before the conduct of the Census in the State.

The rally, organised by 14 civil society organisations, started from Tiddim Ground and covered a distance of 5 km before concluding at Thau Ground, both in Imphal.

Tight security was ensured to prevent any untoward incident. The rallyists held placards that read 'Do not neglect Manipur' and 'No NRC updaten, no Census' and raised slogans demanding that illegal immigrants be identified and deported.

The agitators' spokesperson, Shanta Nahakpam, said, "The BJP raised the issue of illegal immigrants during election campaigns in Assam and West Bengal. Manipur,



too, has several issues, including illegal immigration and border fencing."

"We feel there is no desire on the part of the Centre to conduct NRC (National Register of Citizens) in Manipur. We want NRC updaten and subsequent delimitation of assembly seats," Nahakpam added. Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh had said in March that

the State Government is making every effort to ensure a fair Census.

The Manipur Government had earlier announced that house listing operations for Census 2027 will be conducted in the state between September 1 and 30, with an option for self-enumeration from August 17-31. Elections to the 60-member Assembly are likely to be held early next year.

Row after ASI accused of removing Vagdevi idol from Bhojshala complex

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Indore

A row has erupted over the placement of an ashtadhatu idol of goddess Vagdevi inside the highly sensitive Bhojshala complex and its alleged removal by the Archaeological Survey of India, three weeks after the Madhya Pradesh High Court declared the monument a temple.

A petitioner from the Hindu side has blamed the ASI for the removal of the idol, calling it a contempt of court, while a representative from the Muslim side has objected to its installation. The High



Court, accepting two public interest petitions from the Hindu side, declared Bhojshala a temple of Goddess Vagdevi (Saraswati) on May 15.

The HC stated that the ASI shall have 'full supervisory control' over the preservation, conservation, and regulation of religious access.

Kuldeep Tiwari, one of the petitioners in the Bhojshala case, stated on Monday that some devotees installed an ashtadhatu (eight-metal) idol in the complex last Saturday (June 6), and performed rituals with chanting of mantras.

He claimed that devotees

worshipped the idol throughout Saturday, but in the evening, the ASI allegedly removed it from the Bhojshala complex.

"The removal of the ashtadhatu idol of Goddess Vagdevi by the ASI is highly objectionable. This action is a contempt of court order and an insult to the faith of the devotees," he said in a statement.

Tiwari said that a replica of the Vagdevi idol remains in its place in the Bhojshala complex. He said since the original idol is kept in the British Museum in London, an ashtadhatu idol should be installed in the temple as an alternative until the original

one is returned to India.

He stressed that he is unaware of which devotees had installed the ashtadhatu idol in the complex.

The ASI's response to the allegation of the idol removal is not available.

When asked about the controversy, Dhar area ASI officer Prashant Patankar said he was not authorised to give statements to the media.

Dhar Superintendent of Police Sachin Sharma stated that the May 15 order of the high court and regulations regarding the Bhojshala are being strictly complied with.

The two petitioners of the

Hindu side, who won the case before the Indore bench of the High Court, are insisting on the return of the original idol of Goddess Vagdevi to India and its reinstallation in the Bhojshala.

The high court had noted that the Government of India may consider bringing back the statue of goddess Saraswati from the London Museum and re-establishing the same within the complex.

Zulfikar Pathan, head of the Kamal Maula Masjid Namaz Intezamia Committee in Dhar, said, "In view of this observation by the High Court, no other statue can legally be placed in the

Bhojshala complex."

Pathan demanded that the Islamic inscriptions on the walls of the Bhojshala complex be "fully protected." The HC bench has determined the religious nature of the Bhojshala complex as a Vagdevi (Goddess Saraswati) temple.

The court also overturned the ASI's April 7, 2003, order allowing Muslims to offer prayers at the complex every Friday. This order allowed Hindus to worship at the monument only on Tuesdays.

Following the High Court's decision to declare Bhojshala a temple, Hindus continue to worship at the complex.

J&K sees heavy rush of tourists, pilgrims amid heatwave

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

As a blistering heat wave sweeps across large parts of India, the Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir is experiencing a significant surge in tourist and pilgrim arrivals this summer season.

The visitors continue to give thumbs up to the Union Territory despite two major terror incidents targeting tourists in the past two years. The common link attracting visitors to different parts of Jammu and Kashmir this year is the newly launched Vande Bharat Express, which is running at full capacity.

The cool climes of Gulmarg, Pahalgam, Sonamarg, Gurez valley, and the spiritual pull of the region are also drawing visitors in large numbers, with estimates indicating over 2 lakh tourists and pilgrims arriving in recent weeks. In the

immediate aftermath of the dastardly Pahalgam terror attack on April 22, 2025, that claimed 26 innocent lives, the tourist footfall witnessed a steep fall, and the entire township wore a deserted look for several weeks.

Several other tourist 'hot spots' suffered badly as the UT administration had decided to shut down the parks and other destinations to prevent any collateral damage amid heightened tensions with the neighbouring country.

Earlier, on June 9, 2024, a similar attempt was made by the terrorist handlers sitting across the border to hijack the oath-taking ceremony of Prime Minister Narendra Modi for the third consecutive term in office. A pilgrim bus was ambushed by terrorists, leading to the death of nine pilgrims, returning to Katra base camp from the famous Shiv Khori Shrine, in the Reasi district. The UT admin-



istration's robust security measures also earned praise, as they successfully organised the Amarnath yatra despite grave security concerns in the backdrop of Operation Sindoor last year. This year too, the Union Home Ministry has decided to deploy 670 companies of the central paramilitary forces to conduct the yatra beginning from July 3.

Over 3.5 lakh pilgrims have regis-

tered themselves across different bank branches. Official sources claimed the groundwork by the UT administration to create a conducive atmosphere has resulted in a surge in tourist arrivals this year.

The resilience shown by visitors has once again underscored the undiminished charm of Jammu and Kashmir as a preferred summer destination. The frequent travellers are taking the aerial route to land in the valley. Over three dozen flights land at Srinagar Airport daily.

The majority of pilgrims take the train route to visit the Katra base camp from different parts of the country. In Katra, the Shrine Board authorities are strictly regulating the yatra in view of heavy footfall. On Sunday, the yatra was suspended temporarily after the pilgrim registration crossed the 48000 mark in a single day.



Boats anchored at the Vizhinjam Fishing Harbour in Thiruvananthapuram on Monday

PTI

Safai Karmachari Andolan demands heatwave protection for sanitation workers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Highlighting the brutal intersection of climate crisis and caste injustice, the Safai Karmachari Andolan (SKA) has demanded immediate State intervention and the "right to life" for sanitation workers operating amidst unprecedented, life-threatening heatwaves across the country.

With India currently witnessing some of the highest temperatures globally, making outdoor conditions virtually unlivable, the SKA



pointed out that while heat protection measures are being discussed for other sectors, Safai Karmacharis remain entirely invisible. The organisation noted that workers are being forced to

clean human excreta, drains, sewers, septic tanks, and railway tracks under direct sun exposure and inside toxic spaces filled with poisonous gases, which become even more deadly during extreme heat.

Terming the situation as caste violence intensified by climate injustice, the SKA stated that sanitation workers are collapsing from dehydration, suffocation, exhaustion, and toxic exposure, besides suffering from severe infections, respiratory illnesses, and skin diseases.

The group noted that women sanitation workers face even harsher conditions, spending long hours on roads without access to water, toilets, shade, or healthcare.

To safeguard these vulnerable workers, the SKA has put forward a list of immediate demands, calling for a complete stoppage of all sanitation work under direct sunlight after 9.30 AM during heatwave periods. It has also demanded a comprehensive prohibition of manual sewer and septic tank entry alongside the urgent mechanisation of all san-

itation work across the country.

Furthermore, the frontline advocacy group has sought mandatory provisions of drinking water, ORS, shaded rest areas, washing facilities, and compulsory hourly breaks. To alleviate financial strain, they have demanded a heat-risk compensation allowance of at least 30 per cent additional wages for all sanitation workers.

The demands also include the immediate setup of emergency healthcare camps, comprehensive insurance coverage, and long-term health monitoring for sani-

tation workers and their families.

To ensure strict enforcement, the SKA has called for criminal accountability for contractors and officials who continue to force workers into inhuman heatwave conditions.

Asserting that climate justice is impossible without caste justice, the SKA stated that the lives of Safai Karmacharis cannot continue to be sacrificed in the name of cleanliness, calling for an immediate end to the criminal neglect sustaining underpaid and stigmatised sanitation labour.

CITU calls for nationwide protest over hawker eviction

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Centre of Indian Trade Unions (CITU) has vehemently condemned the brutal mid-night crackdown on railway hawkers, small shop owners, and local residents at the Jadavpur Railway Station area on the intervening night of June 7-8. Terming the eviction drive a barbaric action carried out under the cover of darkness, the trade union body has called for massive nationwide protests in front of railway offices on June 15.

A massive contingent of police personnel, Railway Protection Force (RPF), and other security agencies reportedly used bulldozers and earthmoving machinery to demolish makeshift establishments, destroying the livelihood of hundreds of poor vendors.

When local residents, trade union activists, and students from Jadavpur University peacefully assembled in solidarity to demand rehabilitation and a reasonable time to pack their essentials, they were allegedly met with severe force, intimidation, and violent repression.

CITU strongly condemned the physical assault that resulted in serious injuries to numerous protesters. It also criticised the arbitrary arrest of Srijan Bhattacharya, All India General Secretary of the Students' Federation of India (SFI), along with several other democratic activists.

BRICS meet to focus on food security, farmer welfare: Chouhan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

A five-day meeting of the BRICS grouping will commence in Indore on Tuesday to discuss food security, smart farming, global agricultural trade and farmer welfare, Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said on Monday.

The discussions under India's presidency will include a three-day agriculture working group meeting from June 9 and a two-day BRICS ministerial meeting from June 12, he said.

BRICS is an intergovernmental organisation comprising eleven major emerging economies: Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa, Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, and Indonesia. Highlighting the significance



of the meeting, Chouhan said BRICS is a very strong voice of the developing countries in the world.

"Around half of the world's population dwells in BRICS countries. It has 42 per cent of the global agricultural land and accounts for more than 42 per cent of the produce. Of the 58 crore farmers across the world, 70 per cent small

cultivators live in BRICS nations," he said.

The Union minister said the five-day gathering will deliberate on food security, farmer welfare, nutrition, climate-resilient smart agriculture, facilitation of international agricultural trade, supply chains, "digital agriculture", research, knowledge exchange, artificial intelligence, and robotics.

He said a joint declaration will be issued after consensus among the BRICS agriculture ministers. Chouhan recalled that India has presided over BRICS meetings in 2012, 2016 and 2021. Last month, Chouhan had told reporters in Indore that the BRICS meeting, to be held under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, would prove to be a historic opportunity for the global agriculture sector.

Viksit Bharat national pledge for everyone: Birla

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Chandigarh

Terming the resolve of 'Viksit Bharat' a national pledge that requires the active cooperation of every citizen and institution, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Monday emphasised that laws enacted in legislatures must align with the needs and aspirations of the new generation.

Inaugurating the Commonwealth Parliamentary Association (CPA) India Region Zone-II (North Zone) Conference at the Haryana Legislative Assembly Chamber, Birla stated that India is consistently moving forward on the foundation of long-term policies backed by a stable, strong, and robust legal framework.

The two-day conference is deliberating on the theme, 'Role of an Aware Society and Representatives of the People in Facing Future Challenges and Realising the Goal of Viksit Bharat-2047'.

The inaugural session saw the participation of presiding officers from 12 states, alongside Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairman Harivansh, Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh, and



Om Birla lighting the ceremonial lamp at the inauguration of the 2nd Annual Conference of the Zone-II, Commonwealth Parliamentary Association India Region in Chandigarh

PIONEER PHOTO

Haryana Assembly Speaker Harvinder Kalyan. The Speaker called for a massive mass movement (Janandolan) across the country to ensure that every citizen feels a sense of personal contribution toward building a developed nation.

Expressing confidence in India's youth power, he noted that while the growing population was once viewed as a challenge, the youth demographic has now become India's greatest

strength. To leverage this, he suggested that policies must focus on skill development, quality education, and innovation.

Underlining the importance of public participation in a parliamentary democracy, Birla remarked that regular public discourse and meaningful debates should instil confidence among citizens that the House belongs to them and that their elected representatives are their true voice.

Union Govt has coal stock for 80 days of power: Kishan Reddy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

Union Minister G Kishan Reddy on Monday said that the Centre has adequate coal reserves to meet power generation requirements for 80 days.

Speaking to reporters about the achievements of the NDA Government since 2014, Reddy also said that exploration has begun in the critical mineral blocks acquired in Argentina, and production is expected to commence at the earliest. He said the results of coal gasification projects in the country are expected to become visible within the next two years.

"Earlier, there used to be a shortage of coal. Now, the Government of India has coal reserves sufficient for 80 days of power generation. Since the monsoon season has begun, coal production could face disruptions due to heavy rainfall," the Union Coal and Mines Minister told reporters. "Following the directives of Prime Minister Narendra



Modi, we have maintained coal stocks sufficient for 80 days," he added. Highlighting the importance of critical minerals, Reddy said that the Centre is identifying

critical mineral reserves and undertaking exploration activities.

He added that auctions have also begun in areas where exploration has been completed. The Centre is

encouraging private players to import either processed or semi-processed critical minerals into India, he said.

Reddy said that around 143 abandoned coal mines have been identified for closure, and an action plan has been initiated to close all these mines simultaneously.

"By 2028, the closure of these mines will be completed in a scientific manner," he said.

Alleging that the coal sector was plagued by scams during the previous UPA regime, he said the country is now producing a record 1,040 million tonnes of coal annually following major reforms introduced in the coal and mining sectors over the past 12 years.

He said that five lakh people are directly employed and 25 lakh people are indirectly employed in the coal sector, while 50 lakh people work in the mining sector overall. Reddy said the country has emerged as the world's second-largest producer and consumer of coal. He also said India possesses

the world's fifth-largest coal reserves, while Coal India Ltd remains the largest coal-producing company globally.

He added that nearly 70 per cent of the country's power generation is coal-based, asserting that there is currently no power shortage anywhere in India.

Reddy said the Centre would organise roadshows in Mumbai, Hyderabad, and other cities to promote the recently launched coal gasification scheme.

In May this year, the Union Cabinet approved a Rs 37,500-crore incentive scheme to promote coal gasification projects.

The process converts coal into syngas, which can be used to produce cleaner fuels, chemicals, fertilisers, and hydrogen.

DGCA to probe damage to 3 parked AI aircraft

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Aviation safety regulator DGCA is investigating the incident in which three parked Air India aircraft were damaged at Delhi International Airport after being hit by ground support equipment on Sunday, an official statement said on Monday.

All three aircraft have been grounded for inspection and maintenance, it said.

Three Air India narrow-body aircraft parked at Terminal 2 of Delhi's Indira Gandhi International Airport were damaged on Sunday when ground support equipment hit them due to sudden strong wind and rain, the airport operator said.

"Three Air India A320 aircraft parked at the Delhi



Airport terminal-II were damaged by ground equipment/foreign object debris (FOD) during adverse weather conditions around 16:30 hours (on Sunday)," the statement said.

Due to strong winds, two ground pieces of equipment positioned at adjacent stands and in nearby areas moved from their locations and hit two different aircraft at various positions, causing damage, according to the statement.



Editor's
TAKE

India's growth story at a crossroads

GDP figure of 7.8 per cent is cause for celebration — but read the fine print, and a more anxious story emerges

India's economy delivered a stellar performance in the January-March quarter of 2026. GDP growth came in at 7.8 per cent, easing slightly from 8 per cent in the preceding quarter but comfortably above market expectations of 7.2 per cent, taking full-year FY26 growth to 7.7 per cent. Prime Minister Modi has every reason to proclaim India the world's fastest-growing major economy. The number is real. The achievement is genuine. But a number, however impressive, is not the full story. Look past the headline, and the stress fractures become visible.

Begin with the central bank. The Reserve Bank of India held its repo rate steady at 5.25 per cent for the third consecutive meeting in June, maintaining a neutral stance even as it cut its GDP growth forecast for FY2026-27 sharply to 6.6 per cent from an earlier 6.9 per cent. A central bank that simultaneously freezes rates and slashes its own growth projection is not a central bank radiating confidence. It is one navigating a tightrope. Inflation is now projected to average 5.1 per cent for the current fiscal year, up significantly from an earlier estimate of 4.6 per cent. The "rare Goldilocks" era that RBI Governor Malhotra celebrated just months ago has quietly given way to stagflationary risk. Then there is the rupee downslide. Foreign investors have offloaded over \$20 billion in Indian shares so far this year, placing the rupee under severe pressure and making it one of Asia's worst-performing major currencies in 2026. A sliding currency is more than a financial statistic — it is a barometer of confidence, and right now that barometer is falling. Capital outflows of \$13.7 billion from the equity segment alone since January have prompted the RBI to roll out emergency measures to attract foreign capital. The global backdrop adds further complexity. Economists have cautioned that growth is likely to moderate this year amid rising energy costs and global uncertainty linked to the West Asia conflict. India's ability to source affordable energy has been disrupted, and the RBI's own revised growth trajectory for FY27 ranges between 6.3 per cent and 6.8 per cent across quarters - a step down from FY26's pace. What should India do to keep the momentum alive? Three imperatives stand out.

First, protect the rupee without choking growth. The RBI must strike a balance between currency stability and keeping borrowing costs conducive to investment. Deepening forex reserves, encouraging long-term capital inflows and reducing oil import dependence are the sustainable answers.

Second, broaden the base of growth. While services, manufacturing and construction have driven the recent surge, agriculture grew just 3.6 per cent — a sector that still employs nearly half the workforce. Inclusive growth demands that rural incomes rise, farm productivity improves and the benefits of the services boom reach beyond Tier-1 cities.

Third, stay fiscally disciplined. The temptation to spend India's way through global headwinds is understandable, but deficit overruns would further spook foreign investors and weaken the rupee. The economy needs not just celebration, but honest diagnosis. The numbers are strong. The foundations need tending.

12 years of science in service of India

As India counts down the years to 2047 — the centenary of our independence and the target year for becoming a fully developed nation — science and technology will not merely support that journey; it will determine its pace and character



JITENDRA SINGH

Territory into fragrant fields of purple — a revolution in rural livelihoods born in a laboratory. This, in essence, is what twelve years of sustained commitment to science and technology in India has meant: not the advancement of knowledge for its own sake, but science as a living, breathing force in the daily lives of our citizens.

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi assumed office in 2014, he articulated a vision that challenged us to think of science not as a departmental function but as a national mission. The years that followed have borne that vision out in ways that would have seemed extraordinary a generation ago. Today, India has landed a spacecraft at the Moon's south pole, developed its own antibiotic for the first time, built supercomputers from Pune to Patna, and created a space economy teeming with homegrown startups. But the deeper story — the one that deserves to be told — is how each of these achievements rippled outward into the lives of ordinary people.

Science is no longer confined to laboratories — it has become the single most powerful driver of national development and citizen empowerment.

Consider the farmer. Weather, always the silent sovereign of Indian agriculture, has become far more legible over the last decade. A comprehensive overhaul of our earth observation and forecasting infrastructure now gives farmers accurate, hyperlocal weather predictions — not in the vague language of probability, but with the kind of precision that allows a family to decide whether to harvest tomorrow or wait. When a cyclone forms over the Bay of Bengal today, our early warning systems give coastal communities hours — sometimes days — of advance notice. The difference is not statistical; it is counted in lives saved and livelihoods preserved.

In the mountains and river valleys of Jammu and Kashmir, science arrived in the form of the Aroma Mission — a programme that introduced lavender cultivation and supported farmers with technology, seeds and market linkages. What began as a pilot has since transformed into what is now celebrated as India's Purple Revolution: thousands of farming families earning dignified incomes from aromatic and medicinal plants, with science as the quiet architect of this prosperity. Similar work in saffron expansion, medicinal herb cultivation, and the first-ever introduction of asafetida cultivation in India has demonstrated that innovation, rooted in the soil, can be as transformative as any industrial technology. Rural empowerment through science has extended well beyond agriculture. From 3D-printed housing prototypes designed for affordable rural construction to AI-powered systems that detect food adulteration, technology is being deliberately directed at solving the problems that matter most to the people who can least afford them. The National Mission on Interdisciplinary Cyber Physical Systems — which connects computing, sensing and physical engineering — has established twenty-five Technology Innovation Hubs across the country, seeding more than a thousand startups working on problems as varied as precision agriculture, clean water access, and rural healthcare delivery.

Healing India: The biotechnology breakthrough

Perhaps no domain illustrates the transformative power of Indian science more vividly than biotechnology and healthcare. For decades, India's pharmaceutical strength lay in manufacturing — in producing generic versions of drugs discovered elsewhere. That story is changing. The development of Nafithromycin, India's first indigenously discovered antibiotic in decades, is not merely a scientific milestone: it is a declaration of pharmaceutical self-reliance. Born from a government-supported collaboration between researchers and industry, it signals that India's laboratories can now do what only a handful of nations have managed — innovate at the frontier of drug discovery.

Equally significant is the country's first successful indigenous gene therapy clinical trial for Haemophilia — a condition that requires lifelong, expensive treatment — conducted at the Christian Medical College in Vellore. Gene therapy works by correcting the underlying genetic fault rather than managing its symptoms; for a country with a large burden of genetic disease, the implications are profound. Combined with the GenomeIndia Project, which has now sequenced over ten thousand human genomes drawn from India's extraordinarily diverse population, we are laying the scientific foundation for a future in which medicine is tailored to each patient's biology.

The COVID-19 pandemic revealed, with painful clarity,

When a lavender farmer in the Doda district of Jammu plucks the first blossoms of the season, she is not thinking about science policy. Yet it is precisely a decade of deliberate, mission-driven scientific investment that transformed barren hillsides in the Union



how essential domestic biomedical capacity is to national security. India's response — developing and manufacturing its own vaccines at scale, deploying them across a population of 1.4 billion — drew on years of investment in our biotechnology ecosystem. The Biotechnology Industry Research Assistance Council, or BIRAC, has been instrumental in nurturing biotech startups, bridging the gap between academic research and commercial scale-up, and ensuring that scientific innovation finds its way into the hands of those who need it most. Today, a new generation of bio entrepreneurs is working on precision medicine, sustainable bio-based materials and next-generation diagnostics — and they are doing so from Indian cities and campuses, not just Silicon Valley.

The GenomeIndia Project has sequenced over ten thousand human genomes — laying the foundation for medicine tailored to every Indian's unique biology.

Reaching for the stars, grounding every citizen

On the 23rd of August 2023, as the Vikram lander of Chandrayaan-3 made its final descent toward the south pole — a region no nation had ever reached — millions of Indians watched with a collective held breath. The moment of touchdown was not just a technological triumph; it was a national affirmation. India had done what no one else had managed. What followed — the analysis of the Moon's surface, the data transmitted back across three hundred and eighty thousand kilometres of space — mattered enormously to planetary science. But what mattered just as much was what that landing did to the imagination of a country. India's space story over the past twelve years has been one of simultaneous ambition and utility. While Chandrayaan-3 captured the world's attention, Aditya-L1 — our first dedicated solar observatory — quietly began its mission to study the Sun, advancing our understanding of space weather that affects satellites, power grids, and communication systems on Earth. The SpaDeX mission placed India in an elite club of nations that have demonstrated the ability to dock two spacecraft in orbit — a capability essential for future space stations and crewed missions. Group Captain Shubhanshu Shukla's historic eighteen-day stay aboard the International Space Station brought India's human spaceflight ambitions from aspiration to lived experience.

The transformation of India's space sector goes beyond missions, significant as they are. The Indian Space Policy of 2023 opened the entire value chain — launch vehicles, satellites, ground systems — to private enterprise. The result has been electric. From just eleven space startups in 2014, India today hosts over four hundred, building rockets, designing satellites and creating applications that range from agricultural monitoring to disaster response. Indian launch vehicles have carried three hundred and ninety-nine foreign satellites into orbit since 2014, making us a preferred partner for space agencies around the world. The space economy is no longer a public-sector preserve; it is a national asset being built by thousands of young engineers and entrepreneurs. With the Bharatiya Antariksh Station — India's own space station — envisioned for 2035, and a crewed lunar mission targeted for 2040, the arc of this ambition is long, and its trajectory is upward.

Self-reliance through innovation

Atmanirbhar Bharat — self-reliant India — is not merely a political slogan. In science and technology, it has become a governing philosophy. The National Quantum Mission, backed by more than six thousand crore rupees, is an investment not just in a technology but in India's strategic position in the twenty-first century's most consequential technological race. Quantum computing promises to solve problems that classical computers cannot; quantum communication offers theoretically unbreakable encryption; quantum sensing could transform navigation, medical imaging and geological exploration. India is now building all of these capabilities at home, through Thematic Hubs that bring together universities, research institutions and industry. The National Supercomputing

Mission has seeded high performance computing infrastructure across the country — in Pune, Chennai, Kharagpur and beyond — giving Indian researchers, engineers and startups access to computational power that was once the preserve of a handful of elite institutions. Alongside this, BharatGen — the country's first government-funded multilingual Generative AI programme — is developing large language models that can think and communicate in Indian languages, ensuring that the benefits of artificial intelligence are not confined to English-speaking users.

CSIR's contribution to this vision of self-reliance deserves particular mention. The indigenously developed HANSA-NG trainer aircraft, produced for domestic and export markets, represents a capability built from scratch by Indian engineers. India's first hydrogen fuel-cell powered vessel points toward clean maritime transport. Work on sustainable aviation fuel opens pathways to decarbonising air travel without dependence on foreign technology. The CSIR Innovation Complex, India's first such facility, is designed to be a crucible where laboratory research meets entrepreneurial energy — a place where the distance between a scientific idea and a market-ready product is systematically compressed.

From just 11 space startups in 2014, India today hosts over 400 — a testament to the power of policy, public investment, and entrepreneurial spirit working in concert.

Energy security and future-ready technologies

No account of India's scientific transformation is complete without acknowledging the strategic depth being built in nuclear energy.

The first criticality of the 500 MWe Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor at Kalpakkam in April 2026 is a milestone of historic proportions. Developed entirely by Indian scientists and engineers at the Indira Gandhi Centre for Atomic Research and built by Bharatiya NabhiKiya Vidyut Nigam, this reactor is the critical bridge to the second stage of India's three-stage nuclear programme — a pathway designed to eventually harness our country's vast reserves of thorium, one of the most abundant elements in Indian soil. In an era of energy transition, the ability to generate continuous power from domestic fuel is not merely economical; it is a matter of sovereign security. The nuclear sector has also extended its reach into medicine. The Tata Memorial Hospital's recognition by the International Atomic Energy Agency as a 'Raies of Hope' Anchor Centre, the expansion of cancer hospitals under the Homi Bhabha Cancer Hospital network, and the deployment of advanced radiopharmaceuticals — medicines that use radioactive particles to diagnose and treat cancer — are bringing world-class oncology care to patients across the country. The SHANTI Act of 2025 has modernised the legal architecture of India's nuclear sector, enabling greater participation and investment in an industry that will be central to our clean energy future.

Meanwhile, the Deep Ocean Mission is extending India's scientific reach into the last great unexplored frontier on our planet. Our ocean floor holds vast reserves of minerals essential for clean energy technologies — polymetallic nodules and cobalt-rich crusts that could reduce India's dependence on imported critical minerals. The mission is also building the underwater vehicle and sensor technologies that give India strategic and scientific presence in its maritime domain.

Towards Viksit Bharat: Science as destiny

As India counts down the years to 2047 — the centenary of our independence and the target year for becoming a fully developed nation — science and technology will not merely support that journey; they will determine its pace and character. The investments made over the last twelve years have created not just institutions and infrastructure, but something more durable: a culture of scientific ambition, entrepreneurial energy and national confidence.

The Anusandhan National Research Foundation, created to transform India's research ecosystem through mission-led science, academia-industry collaboration and empowerment of young researchers, and the newly constituted Research, Development and Innovation Fund with a corpus of one lakh crore rupees, represent the largest bet India has ever placed on its own intellectual capacity. They signal a conviction — hardened by twelve years of evidence — that the solutions to our most pressing challenges lie within our own laboratories, campuses and communities.

The lavender farmer in Doda, the genomics researcher in Vellore, the space startup founder in Bengaluru, the nuclear engineer in Kalpakkam — they are all characters in the same story. It is the story of a nation that chose, deliberately and decisively, to place science at the centre of its development. What the last twelve years have built is not a portfolio of achievements but a foundation — sturdy, deep and wide — upon which a developed, self-reliant and scientifically confident India will rise.

The writer is Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Science & Technology, Earth Sciences, and MoS, Prime Minister's Office, Personnel, Atomic Energy & Space, Government of India

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NEET SECURITY MEASURES RAISE SERIOUS QUESTIONS NATIONWIDE

It is both shocking and unfortunate that all experts involved in setting, moderating and translating the NEET-UG 2026 retest question papers have reportedly been moved to a secure, undisclosed location and placed under strict isolation protocols, with virtually no external communication permitted during the final stages of paper preparation. Reports indicate that these restrictions will remain in force until the completion of the re-examination on June 21.

Such measures are unprecedented in the history of India's education system and reflect the deep mistrust that has emerged following repeated allegations of question paper leaks and examination irregularities. While ensuring the integrity of examinations is essential, placing experts under lockdown raises

questions about the credibility of the system and the circumstances that have made such extraordinary precautions necessary.

Equally striking is the reported decision to transport NEET-UG question papers using Indian Air Force aircraft to prevent pilferage and leakage. These steps underscore the extent of concern surrounding the conduct of one of the country's most important entrance examinations.

The developments suggest an urgent need for a thorough review of the examination framework. In my view, the best solution would be to abolish NEET and allow state governments to select candidates for medical education based on their performance in the Plus Two examination.

THARCUS S FERNANDO | CHENNAI

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Questions over electoral roll purge

In its May 2026 judgment on the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), the Supreme Court of India upheld the actions of the Election Commission (EC). The Court relied on the phrases "superintendence, direction and control" and "free and fair elections" in Article 324 of the Constitution to support its decision. The verdict effectively grants the EC extensive authority over the electoral process. Although the Court clarified that the formal determination of citizenship rests with the competent authority, it held that the EC could refuse enrolment or initiate deletion from electoral rolls if it was not satisfied that the statutory requirements had been met. This has effectively created a category of "citizens without voting rights", with nearly six crore people reportedly removed from electoral rolls across 13 states. In West Bengal alone, around 27 lakh people possessing documentary proof of citizenship were excluded owing to what the Commission termed "logical discrepancies".

The Supreme Court is also examining the validity of the law that allows the ruling party to nominate Election Commissioners. A ruling on the composition of the selection committee should ideally have preceded the judgment on the SIR.

LPG hike hits commoners

State-owned fuel retailers have raised the price of a 14.2-kg domestic LPG cylinder by ₹29, effective nationwide. This hike, triggered by rising global energy costs and the West Asia crisis, is the second increase in three months, pushing the retail price in Delhi to ₹942.

The increase follows an earlier hike of ₹60 per cylinder on March 7, after the conflict in West Asia disrupted global energy supplies and drove up international fuel prices.

For millions of households already grappling with rising living costs, repeated increases in cooking gas prices place additional pressure on monthly budgets. The impact is particularly severe on middle-class and lower-income families, for whom LPG is an essential household necessity.

In this context, practical measures to reduce fuel consumption assume greater significance. Nandita Iyer, a health coach, recently shared a series of useful tips on Instagram aimed at helping households cut LPG consumption by up to 50 per cent.

Such simple changes in cooking practices can not only reduce fuel usage but also help families manage their expenses more effectively during a period of rising energy costs.

Fire safety cannot be ignored

The devastating fire at the Flourish Stay B&B in Malviya Nagar, Delhi, which claimed 21 lives, including those of foreign nationals, exposes critical failures in safety compliance, illegal operations and emergency management. The fact that the establishment was allegedly licensed for only six rooms but was illegally operating 25 underscores the deadly risks posed by unregulated expansion and inadequate municipal oversight.

Reports suggest that the building lacked the mandatory No Objection Certificate (NOC) and failed to comply with essential fire safety norms. It is reprehensible that, despite the National Building Code of India (NBC) prescribing key safety measures relating to fire protection, structural integrity and sustainability, many multi-storey commercial buildings continue to violate safety regulations with impunity, thereby putting human lives at risk.

To minimise such tragedies, fire safety audits should be made mandatory across the country and entrusted to qualified third-party agencies with the necessary expertise. A comprehensive fire safety audit can identify potential hazards associated with day-to-day operations and recommend corrective measures to prevent accidents and save lives.

Emerging challenges to national security in the 21st century

The challenges of the twenty-first century demand a comprehensive and integrated approach to security. Terrorism, emerging technologies, cyber threats, financial crimes, geopolitical realignments and information warfare are interconnected issues that require coordinated responses



KARNAL SINGH

National security today is passing through a period of unprecedented transformation. For decades, security was viewed largely in terms of territorial defence, military preparedness and protection against external aggression, and action against terrorists and elements working against the nation. While these traditional threats continue to remain important, the security environment has become far more complex. Technological advances, globalisation, digital connectivity and geopolitical shifts have created new vulnerabilities that transcend national borders. Security today is not only the exclusive responsibility of governments, armed forces and law enforcement agencies, but it also requires the participation of industry, academia and citizens alike.

One of the most significant challenges facing nations across the world is terrorism and violent extremism. Terrorist organisations have continuously adapted to changing circumstances. They have effectively utilised social media, encrypted communication platforms, digital propaganda and international financial networks to spread their ideology and recruit vulnerable individuals. While strong counter-terrorism measures remain essential, experience has shown that force alone cannot eliminate the threat. There is a growing need to focus on de-radicalisation and counter-radicalisation programmes. The objective should be to prevent vulnerable youth from falling prey to extremist ideologies and to reintegrate misguided individuals into mainstream society. Equally important is the disruption of terror financing networks. Terrorist organisations survive on financial support generated through narcotics trafficking, extortion, smuggling, money laundering, misuse of charities and, increasingly, through digital and crypto-based transactions. Cutting off these financial lifelines is often more effective than merely targeting operatives.

The rapid emergence of new technologies presents both opportunities and challenges. Artificial Intelligence is already transforming governance, industry, health-care, defence and law enforcement. AI can enhance surveillance, improve predictive policing, strengthen intelligence analysis and assist in decision-making. At the same time, it can be misused to create deepfakes, conduct sophisticated cyber-attacks, manipulate public opinion and automate disinformation campaigns. Similarly, quantum computing has the potential to revolutionise scientific research and data processing. However, it also threatens existing encryption systems that protect military communications, financial transactions and sensitive government databases. Nations that fail to invest in these technologies may find themselves strategically disadvantaged in the coming decades.

Cybersecurity has emerged as one of the most critical dimensions of national security. Modern economies are heavily dependent on digital infrastructure. Power grids, banking systems, telecommunications networks, transportation systems and government services are all interconnected through cyberspace. This interconnectedness has created enormous efficiencies but has also increased vulnerability. Cyber-attacks today can disrupt essential services, compromise sensitive information and inflict significant economic damage without a single shot being fired. Cybercrime has become a global industry involving ransomware attacks, online fraud, digital extortion, identity theft and financial scams. Public awareness and cyber hygiene are therefore as important as technological safeguards. Every citizen using a mobile phone or digital payment platform is now a potential target and must be educated accordingly.

Financial security is increasingly becoming an integral component of national security. Economic crimes, money laundering, terror financing and large-scale financial fraud undermine public confidence and weaken institutions. Criminal and hostile actors exploit global financial systems to move illicit funds across jurisdictions. The challenge becomes even greater with the growth of digital payments and virtual assets. Strengthening anti-money laundering frameworks, enhancing financial intelligence capabilities and improving financial literacy among



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FINANCIAL SECURITY IS INCREASINGLY BECOMING AN INTEGRAL COMPONENT OF NATIONAL SECURITY. ECONOMIC CRIMES, MONEY LAUNDERING, TERROR FINANCING AND LARGE-SCALE FINANCIAL FRAUD UNDERMINE PUBLIC CONFIDENCE AND WEAKEN INSTITUTIONS. CRIMINAL AND HOSTILE ACTORS EXPLOIT GLOBAL FINANCIAL SYSTEMS TO MOVE ILLICIT FUNDS ACROSS JURISDICTIONS

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citizens are essential steps in protecting economic stability and national security.

The international environment is also witnessing profound changes. The global balance of power is undergoing significant realignment. Strategic competition among major powers, regional conflicts and disruptions in global supply chains are reshaping the world order. Critical maritime routes and strategic choke points such as the Strait of Hormuz continue to influence global energy security and trade. Any disruption in these regions can have immediate consequences for national economies. Nations must therefore prepare for an increasingly uncertain geopolitical environment by building strategic resilience and diversifying critical dependencies.

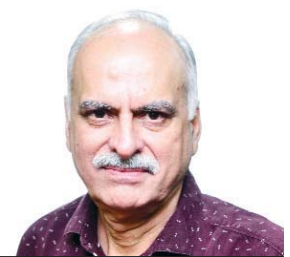
Social media has become a powerful instrument capable of influencing public opinion on an unprecedented scale. While it has democratised communication and empowered citizens, it has also become a platform for misinformation, propaganda, fake news and psychological operations. Adversarial actors can exploit these platforms to deepen social divisions, spread communal tensions and undermine trust in institutions. Information warfare has become an important component of modern conflict, making digital literacy and the responsible use of social media critical national security concerns.

Technological developments have also transformed espionage and intelligence gathering. Traditional intelligence operations are now supplemented by cyber espionage, data theft, surveillance technologies and influence operations conducted through digital platforms. Sensitive government information, intellectual property and critical technologies have become valuable targets. Protecting strategic information assets is therefore as important as protecting physical borders.

Finally, national security must be viewed through a broader social and cultural lens. A society divided by mistrust, misinformation and social tensions becomes vulnerable to external manipulation and internal instability. Social cohesion, constitutional values, cultural confidence and responsible citizenship are important pillars of national resilience. Security is not merely the absence of threats; it is the presence of strong institutions, informed citizens and a shared commitment to national interests.

The challenges of the twenty-first century demand a comprehensive and integrated approach to security. Terrorism, emerging technologies, cyber threats, financial crimes, geopolitical realignments and information warfare are interconnected issues that require coordinated responses. Building a secure nation will depend not only on military strength and technological capability but also on social resilience, economic stability and an informed citizenry. The nations that successfully adapt to these emerging realities will be best positioned to safeguard their sovereignty, prosperity and security in the years ahead.

Ladakh on the cusp of ushering in people's rule



ANIL ANAND

Valour and chivalry of Ladakh, the hilly desert of India, is exemplary. It is the largest Lok Sabha constituency of India, area-wise, which in contemporary India has a rich history of standing up during war times to defend the nation. During peace times, Ladakhis have been persistently fighting for their dignity, identity, political empowerment and protection of basic rights. They may be less in number, with nearly 3.50 lakh people inhabiting the large and barren swath of Ladakh, but their resilience in fighting for their identity, ethnicity and culture, while steadfastly remaining nationalist, is remarkable and unmatched. This commitment has once again borne fruit, with an adamant Centre, after trying all weapons

of statecraft to disregard people's demand for protective rights and political empowerment, agreeing to their demands, short of granting statehood and bringing the tribal-dominated area under the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution to safeguard its tribal identity. There is a breakthrough after talks with representatives of the Apex Body, Leh (ABL), and Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA), held in Delhi after a discomforting delay. The leaders have reached an "in-principle understanding" with the Centre on "restoring democracy in Ladakh" and providing "constitutional safeguards on the lines of Article 371A, 371F and 371G", following talks with senior Union Home Ministry officials. Incidentally, these are provisions applicable in states such as Nagaland, Sikkim and Mizoram.

The parent UT of Jammu and Kashmir, out of which Ladakh UT was carved, is also demanding the same, but without any worthwhile public pressure, though its main demand is restoration of statehood. The Ladakhis excelled once again because they stood united, unmindful of the wrath of the powers that be, which is not the case in Jammu and Kashmir, particularly the Jammu region, which has wholeheartedly supported the BJP in successive elections. On the contrary, Jammu and Kashmir, particularly Jammu, stands politically and socially divided, thereby giving a leeway to the Centre to disregard its feelings. It also signals that the Ladakh civil society groups have scaled down their demand for Sixth Schedule status and full statehood. However, there is a caveat attached to this "in-principle understanding", with a promise to invoke provisions of Article 371, which was earlier not acceptable to Ladakh leaders. Leaders such as former BJP MP Mr Thupstan Chhewang, who later quit the party and is also a former head of the Ladakh Buddhist Association, were of the view that acceptance of this provision is a stepping stone and not an end in itself, with people reserving their right to agitate in future. Surely, it is a step forward and an ode to the rare unity between the Leh and Kargil regions of Ladakh on broader issues of identity, overcoming all their differences.

As per the talks, Ladakh will have full legislative, executive and financial powers vested in elected representatives through a UT-level Assembly. The elected executive head (proposed to be a Chief Minister) will have direct administrative control over the entire UT bureaucracy, headed by the Chief Secretary. The UT's budget will be managed by the elected body, unlike the present mechanism where the Lieutenant Governor is the supreme controlling authority. Safeguards for the protection of Ladakh's land, environment, culture and jobs will be established under Article 371.

August 5, 2019, was a historic day in the history of Ladakh when the long-standing demand for separation from Jammu and Kashmir and the creation of a Union Territory (UT) was accepted, though not fully in accordance with the wishes of the people. It did not happen suddenly but came after more than four decades of struggle in varied forms.

Definitely, a history of sorts was created, but simultaneously a new phase of struggle began, centred on the protection of the tribal identity of the people through the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution, along with political and administrative empowerment. These factors are missing in the UT model, which is more Delhi-centric and has increased the sensitivity of the hilly region, thereby making it more vulnerable than ever before. All this was promised by the ruling BJP, resulting in the party winning the Ladakh Lok Sabha seat twice before losing it the third time for failing to deliver on its promises. The biggest among these was the protection of identity and the fragile environment.

Ladakh is once again on the cusp of taking a step forward after a prolonged agitation resulting in casualties and the arrest of prominent environmentalist and social activist Mr Sonam Wangchuk under the draconian National Security Act (NSA), followed by his deportation to a Rajasthan jail in a climatically diverse environment. This proved to be a turning point. His NSA detention was suddenly withdrawn by the Centre just before the Supreme Court was to take a final call on his petition. Ostensibly, mounting public pressure showed its impact. Both the ABL and KDA leaders feel that the offer, which has been agreed upon "in principle", is an ice-breaking move. However, they are keeping their fingers crossed until they discuss the proposal back home with the people of Leh and Kargil and a formal notification is issued after subsequent meetings.

The leaders felt that "restoring democracy in Ladakh" and providing "constitutional safeguards under the spirit of Articles 371A, 371F and 371G", as proposed by senior Home Ministry officials, is a step forward. These provisions are applicable in states such as Nagaland, Sikkim and Mizoram. The UTs of Ladakh and Jammu and Kashmir have been demanding similar safeguards for the last six years pending restoration of statehood.

"In this model, the legislative, executive and financial powers will rest with elected representatives through a Union Territory-level legislative body," the ABL and KDA said in a statement, adding: "All bureaucrats of the UT, including the Chief Secretary, will come under the executive head of the UT-level elected body (proposed to be Chief Minister)."

The "in-principle" agreement is silent on the demand for inclusion under the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution and the granting of statehood status. Are the people of Ladakh (read their representatives) ready to forgo these demands? Maybe for the time being. Apex Body of Ladakh co-chairman Chhering Dorje Lakruk said, "A broad agreement has been reached on having a representative administration. It would have legislative and financial powers.

The bureaucrats will work under the authority of the Chief Minister. Land, jobs and culture would be protected under Article 371. Finer details will be worked out in further meetings." "Discussions are still underway," Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) co-chairman Sajjad Kargili said in a statement. "We have shared our draft proposals demanding statehood and Sixth Schedule safeguards, and the government has now responded with certain suggestions. It is expected to come up with a formal draft before the next meeting," said Kargili.

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Yogakshema and Antyodaya in practice: Assessing UP's governance shift under Yogi Adityanath



SUNNY SINGH

Governance is not only the management of a territory. It is the consecration of power into the service of the people. That conviction is ancient in India. Kautilya stated it in the Arthashastra with the economy of a practitioner through prajasukhe sukham rajnah in the happiness of the subject lies the happiness of the king. The Mahabharata's Santi Parva pressed it further: the king does not rest while his subjects suffer. That two minds working from such opposite stations, one from a functioning court and one from the wreckage of Kurukshetra, arrived at the same conclusion about sovereignty is the settled civilisational verdict of Bharata. The condition of the weakest citizen is the only honest measure of those who govern.

Uttar Pradesh in 2017 was, by that measure, a failing state. The administrative degeneration of the preceding decades was real, structural and cumulative. Organised crime had fashioned a parallel sovereign order under state patronage. Dynastic absolutism had converted public institutions into instruments of private extraction. The state's share in national life had contracted economically, socially and in terms of basic security. The BIMARU designation was not only a demographic label. It was a verdict delivered by the

state's own record. The commentariat that affixed it across three decades has since conspicuously refused to read the acquittal. Their silence in the face of transformation is, in its own way, testimony enough. The change which occurred in 2017 was not a transfer of power in the routine sense. It was the recovery of Yogakshema as a governing obligation. The just acquisition of what is not yet possessed (yoga) and the full preservation of what has already been gained (kshema) were restored as the sovereign creed of the state.

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath drew Kautilya's triad of *raksana* (protection), *palana* (sustenance) and welfare assurance out of theoretical discourse and reinstated each as an operational principle of administration.

The Zero Tolerance policy against crime was the first and most visible expression of this recovery. For decades, the sociology of fear in UP had run in one direction. By 2026, it had been reversed. The farmer moving produce at night, the trader keeping his shop open after dark, the woman travelling through districts that once carried menacing reputations their daily experience has changed in ways every resident of the state can describe and no single statistic fully captures.

Yet the statistics are available. A substantial decline in organised crime and the conviction of 1,25,985 criminals through Operation Conviction stand as the measurable record. Kautilya understood that when danda is just and inexorable, the accumulated energy of a society flows towards creation. That principle has been verified in practice. The extraction economy of the earlier decades



rested on one structural condition: that a rupee travelling from the treasury to its intended beneficiary would pass through enough hands to be substantially diminished en route. Direct Benefit Transfer, integrated e-governance platforms and the Darpan Portal collapsed that journey. Over ₹7 lakh crore has since reached beneficiaries without leakage. An entire architecture of intermediary theft that had operated with impunity for a generation has been dismantled. The governance machinery that has replaced it is, in its essentials, a disciplined rendering of Kautilyan administrative principles in contemporary form.

At this point, the standard critique must be met directly. The charge runs that UP's transformation is Hindu-majoritarian assertion dressed in the language of development. The invocation of Kautilya and the renewal of Ayodhya, the argument goes, constitute cultural politics repackaged as universal governance.

The response is equally direct. The secular-development consensus that governed Uttar Pradesh

for the five decades preceding 2017 delivered, by its own measurable record, neither secularism nor development. Its administrative inheritance was a state from which the most marginalised-Dalits, the rural poor and the unhoused woman-remained structurally excluded. A politics that secured its legitimacy through competitive minority appeasement while leaving the condition of the governed unchanged is not secularism. It is the most sophisticated form of social extraction a democratic system permits. NITI Aayog does not record the religion of those lifted from multidimensional poverty. It records their nutritional status, their access to water and their ability to educate their children. More than 6 crore citizens of Uttar Pradesh have crossed that threshold. That number is the only response the charge of optics deserves.

The philosophical depth of this model finds its closest modern analogue in Pandit Deendayal Upadhyaya's Antyodaya. The distance between the two frameworks is worth registering. For Kautilya, the welfare of the last subject is shaped by the logic of state capacity. A neglected people weakens the foundation of everything the king rules. Upadhyaya argues from a civilisational perspective. In Ekadma Manavdarshan, the condition of the antyaya is a moral indictment of the entire social order that produced it. It is not a management failure.

The Yogi government's welfare architecture has operated in that moral register. Over 56 lakh houses under housing schemes such as PMAY and CMAY, tap water connections to more than 2.02 crore rural households under Har Ghar Jal, and a record budget of ₹9.12 lakh crore for FY 2026-27 represent

this commitment in concrete form. These are not protections in the Kautilyan sense. They are instruments of ascent.

Antyodaya does not ask whether the last person has been shielded from the worst. It asks whether they have been given the conditions to rise. The GSDP surging towards a ₹40 lakh crore economy, more than 156 crore tourist visits recorded in 2025, including over 36 lakh foreign tourists, and the steady expansion of exports and investment tell one part of the story. More than 6 crore people lifted from poverty tell another. These are not two separate achievements reported side by side. They describe the same governing project, one read in aggregate wealth and the other in individual human condition. That both have moved together is the most honest account of what Uttar Pradesh has become.

The condition Kautilya named matsya nyaya, in which the large devour the small while the state looks away, had been the lived political reality of Uttar Pradesh for thirty years. That condition has been broken. Yogakshema has been returned to its proper place. And the last man, for whom neither dynasty nor commentariat had any practical use, has been raised. That is the record. That is the transformation.

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SC directs settlement in Ardee group family dispute

New Delhi: The Supreme Court has directed the execution of a settlement in a dispute involving the family of the late real estate developer Ashok Varma, related to the Ardee Group and associated family assets.

A bench comprising Justices JK Maheshwari and Atul S Chandurkar took note of the report filed by the mediator appointed by it and ordered the parties to implement the same.

The property dispute involving the Ardee Group involves Shafali Varma and Shibani Varma Kapur, daughters of the late Ashok Varma, regarding control of the family's real estate assets and business interests.

The top court had appointed former top court judge Justice Kurian Joseph, as a mediator to assist the parties in reaching an amicable settlement.

"Having considered the gravity of the issue, we propose that the parties should go for mediation, on which senior counsel representing the parties have agreed to take recourse of mediation.

"By the consent of the senior counsel for both the parties, we request Justice Kurian Joseph, former Judge of this Court, to burn the midnight oil and to help in amicable resolution, if possible," the bench had said in its order. (PTI)



SC backs NGT order on landlord liability

New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Monday upheld an order of the National Green Tribunal which held that a landlord cannot be liable for environmental violations allegedly committed by his tenant's chemical unit.

A bench of Justices Satish Chandra Sharma and Sanjeev Sachdeva refused to interfere with the Tribunal's November 14, 2025 order.

The top court was hearing a plea filed by the Gujarat Pollution Control Board (GPCB) challenging an order passed by the National Green Tribunal (NGT), which set aside its order that held a Surat landlord liable for environmental violations allegedly committed by his tenant's chemical unit. The NGT had held that owner Jagmohan Lachiram Jalan could not be made to pay interim environmental damage compensation of ₹25 lakh for offences committed by the industrial unit operating on his rented premises. This case was initiated after a closure direction issued by the GPCB on October 16, 2021, against a company involved in dye-intermediate manufacturing operation without fulfilling mandatory consent to establish guidelines. (PTI)



Physical relationship between consent adults not character flaw, says SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court has held that physical relationship between two consenting unmarried adults cannot be a ground to draw an adverse impression about the character of the person in that relationship.



which prohibits two consenting unmarried adults to have a relationship of their choice," the bench said.

The top court allowed the appeal filed by the candidate and upheld a Telangana High Court single judge's order directing reconsideration of his appointment to the post of Stipendiary Cadet Trainee Police Constable.

Telangana State Level Police Recruitment Board had cancelled his appointment on the ground that a rape on

India needs better judges, not just more judges



Every discussion on judicial reform in India eventually arrives at the same destination: the shortage of judges. Court vacancies, pendency and delays dominate headlines and policy debates. Yet a more fundamental question often escapes serious scrutiny. Are we paying enough attention to the quality of judges entering the system?

The answer, unfortunately, is not reassuring. India's district judiciary constitutes the backbone of the justice delivery system. For the overwhelming majority of citizens, justice begins and ends at the trial court level. Very few litigants ever reach a High Court, and fewer still find themselves before the Supreme Court. Yet the recruitment of judicial officers continues to be fragmented across States, governed by differing standards, varying examination patterns and inconsistent evaluation mechanisms.

The scale of the system itself demands greater attention. India today has sanctioned strength of around 26,000 judges functioning across the district judiciary for exercising sovereign judicial power over

the lives, liberties, properties and businesses of citizens. Such a system cannot afford uneven standards.

One of the most troubling features of the present recruitment process is the tendency of some states to repeatedly reduce qualifying marks whenever an inadequate number of candidates clear the examination. In certain instances, qualifying thresholds have reportedly been brought down to levels that would be considered unacceptable in any other premier public service. The objective may be understandable i.e. vacancies must be filled; but judicial office cannot become an exercise in numerical completion. A vacancy in the judiciary is certainly undesirable, but a poorly trained or inadequately qualified judge may inflict far greater damage over decades of service. The quality of justice depends substantially upon the quality of judges.

A judicial officer is expected to interpret complex statutes, appreciate evidence, assess witness credibility, protect constitutional rights, understand commercial disputes, deal with cybercrime, determine questions of liberty and, above all, write reasoned judgments. These responsibilities demand intellectual rigour, legal scholarship, integrity and temperament. They cannot be com-



promised merely because vacancies need to be filled.

This is where the case for an All India Judicial Service (AIJS) becomes compelling. The Constitution has contemplated such a possibility. Yet political hesitation, federal concerns and institutional resistance have prevented its implementation. The time has perhaps come to revisit the idea with seriousness and urgency.

India recruits its finest administrative talent through nationally competitive examinations for the IAS, IPS and other All India Services. There is little reason why the judicial branch should not benefit from a similarly rigorous, merit-based and nationally standardised recruitment mechanism. An AIJS would not merely create uniformity; it would establish a national benchmark for excellence in judicial recruitment.

Critics often argue that local laws, regional languages and federal sensitivities make a national judicial service impractical. These concerns deserve respect but not surrender. The solution lies not in abandoning reform but in designing it intelligently. Language training, state-specific legal modules and probationary postings can address most operational challenges. What cannot be justified is the continuation of a system where the quality of recruitment varies dramatically depending upon geography.

However, recruitment alone will not solve the problem. The second and equally important reform concerns judicial training. India needs a comprehensive network of world-class judicial academies dedicated to producing not merely judges, but judicial leaders. Training cannot be reduced to a brief induction programme followed by decades of learning through trial and error. Judicial education must become a continuous process throughout a judge's career.

More importantly, India is failing to utilise one of its greatest institutional resources i.e. retired judges of the High Courts and the Supreme Court. Every year, some of the finest legal minds retire from constitutional courts carrying with them decades of judicial wisdom, courtroom experience and jurisprudential understanding. Much of this invaluable knowledge remains underutilised. The nation invests enormously in creating great judges; it should not permit that investment to dissipate upon retirement.

Every retired High Court and Supreme Court judge should be encouraged and perhaps institutionally obligated to devote two-three years after retirement to judicial education and mentoring. Their role should not be ceremonial. They should teach judgment writing, constitutional values, evidence appreciation, ethics, case management, commercial law, technology and judicial temperament.

No textbook can replace the lived experience of a judge who has spent decades deciding complex questions of law and justice. Such an arrangement would create a culture of mentorship within the judiciary. Young judicial officers would benefit directly from the wisdom of those who have occupied the highest judicial offices in the country. Equally important, it would help create uniform standards of excellence across states and regions. The conversation on judicial reform must therefore evolve.

For too long, the focus has remained overwhelmingly on vacancies and pendency. Numbers matter, but numbers alone do not deliver justice. A system with more judges but weaker standards may produce more judgments without necessarily producing better justice.

India's constitutional democracy deserves a judicial system built upon merit, excellence and continuous learning. An All India Judicial Service, coupled with robust judicial academies led by retired High Court and Supreme Court judges, can transform the quality of justice for generations.

Vivek Narayan Sharma is an Advocate-on-Record at the Supreme Court of India, constitutional expert, Accredited Mediator and Arbitrator, with over 26 years of experience in constitutional law, litigation, arbitration and public policy

Delhi HC seeks Centre, CBSE response to NSUI plea over on-screen marking row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

The Delhi High Court on Monday sought the stand of the Centre and the CBSE on a petition by the Congress' student wing seeking an independent inquiry into the alleged irregularities in the on-screen marking (OSM) system for Class 12 exam.

Issuing notice on a PIL by the National Students' Union of India (NSUI), a vacation bench of Justices Neena Bansal Krishna and Madhu Jain asked the central government and the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) to file their responses and listed the matter for hearing on June 12.

The petitioner submitted that the CBSE closed the portal for verifying and revaluing answer sheets last night and requested a direction to keep it open for affected students for one month.

Counsel for CBSE, advocate M A Niyaz, submitted that the authorities extended the deadline for closing the portal from time to time, and the education board was duly addressing the grievances of aggrieved students.

He also objected to the maintainability of the PIL, emphasising that the NSUI was a student wing of a political party.

"We don't want education to be politicised like this," the counsel submitted.

NSUI counsel said that it filed the PIL on behalf of minors and that association with a political party was not a disqualification.

The PIL, filed through advocate Rishav Ranjan, also seeks manual rechecking and physical verification of answer sheets of aggrieved students.

In the petition, the NSUI has said the sharp decline in overall performance in this year's Class 12 results has led



to widespread concern among students and parents regarding the fairness, consistency and reliability of the OSM system, especially in the light of several requests for scanned answer books and complaints on discrepancies and technical issues acknowledged by the CBSE.

It has asserted that concerns around OSM were not confined to a "small set of students" and those whose answer sheets were affected by scanning defects, mismatch errors or other technical failures cannot be made to suffer because of deficiencies in the system.

"The Respondent Number 2 (CBSE) itself acknowledged, through its own public communications, that the portal for obtaining scanned copies of answer books suffered technical glitches and that a very large number of applications, approximately 1,27,146 applications concerning 3,87,399 scanned answer books, had been submitted in a very short time," the plea has submitted.

Delhi HC directs removal of social media posts against judge over Saidulajab building collapse case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Monday directed social media platforms to remove certain allegedly contemptuous content targeting a sitting judge in relation to the collapse of a multi-storey building in Saidulajab here last month.

"Remove everything forthwith," a vacation bench of Justices Neena Bansal Krishna and Madhu Jain said while dealing with a plea by the Delhi High Court Bar Association (DHCBA) seeking criminal contempt action against social media user Dr Kapil Kakar for his "scandalous" videos holding the sitting high court judge responsible for the incident which claimed six lives.

DHCBA president senior advocate N Hariharan informed that Kakar



uploaded videos on social media platforms in which he made contemptuous allegations against the judge, who allegedly earlier heard a case regarding the illegal construction in the building. Asserting that it was "not

so absurd, why don't you remove them? Once it comes to your notice, why can't you do it on your own," the court asked the social media platforms.

"This is not one case. This is happening daily," it further said.

The counsel appearing for Meta, Google and LinkedIn assured the court that the videos would be taken down as per its directions.

Even as the DHCBA asserted that damage had already been done by the offending content, the court remarked, "This is not genuine information. Public memory is short. This is only to scandalise."

The DHCBA also prayed that besides removing the videos, the social media account for the alleged contemnor should also be blocked.

Amicus curiae urges SC to issue directions to MCD over unauthorised constructions in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A court-appointed amicus curiae has moved the Supreme Court seeking various directions, including the one asking civic body MCD to file an affidavit indicating survey conducted and action taken against illegal and unauthorised constructions in the national Capital.

The urgent intervention has been sought following the collapse of an allegedly illegally constructed five-storey building in Delhi's Saidulajab

area that claimed six lives and injured at least 14 people on May 30.

On March 25, a bench comprising Justices Ahsanuddin Amanullah and R Mahadevan, while hearing a matter arising from Tamil Nadu, expressed serious concern over widespread violations of building regulations and the alleged failure of municipal authorities to prevent unauthorised constructions.

It had directed a pan-India inquiry into the misuse of residential properties and illegal land-use conversions.

Senior advocate and amicus curiae Ajit Kumar Sinha, in a status report filed on June 4 through advocate Govind Jee, has approached the top court seeking urgent intervention following the collapse of the building in Saidulajab area.

Sinha said the tragedy underscored the larger problem of rampant illegal constructions and alleged regulatory failures.

The report said the building, located at Saidulajab, was allegedly booked by municipal authorities on multiple occasions for unauthorised con-



struction. According to municipal records cited in the report, violations were first recorded in 2012, followed by further bookings in 2015 for additional floors.

The report alleges that despite these actions, no effective enforcement measures were taken and construction continued, culminating in the addition of fourth and fifth floors shortly before the collapse. The amicus has contended that the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) failed to discharge its statutory obligations by not taking

timely action, including sealing the premises or preventing further construction despite repeated indications of violations.

In view of the facts, the Court "may be pleased to direct the MCD to file an affidavit indicating survey conducted and action taken against illegal and unauthorised constructions as well as cases concerning unauthorised use of residential premises of all properties located within the precincts of the Municipal Corporation in Delhi".

ANIMAL RIGHTS GROUPS' PROTEST ON JUNE 13 AGAINST SC ORDER

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Animal rights activists on Monday raised concerns over the recent Supreme Court directions on the relocation of stray dogs from public spaces, alleging that it could weaken safeguards against cruelty to animals.



Addressing a press conference organised by the Conference for Human Rights (India) here, the activists said the focus should be on strengthening sterilisation and vaccination programmes rather than removing dogs from their habitats. They argued that the present situation was the result of years of inadequate implementation of animal birth control and anti-rabies measures by civic authorities.

The activists also announced a protest at Jantar Mantar on June 13 to voice their concerns over the court's directions and their implementation. Speaking at the event, advocate Nanita Sharma said certain provisions of the order granted protection to officials implementing the directions but did not clearly specify mechanisms.

PIOTECH

AI debate in education is asking the wrong question; India must look beyond ChatGPT fears

As Artificial Intelligence (AI) rapidly enters classrooms, homes and study routines, the public debate around AI in education has largely focused on one anxiety: is AI making children lazy, dependent or less capable of thinking deeply? In this conversation with *The Pioneer*, Rohit Kumar Garg speaks about AI, equity, Government schools, and why the real question is not whether AI belongs in education, but which child it is being designed for. An IIT Kharagpur Computer Science product, Garg is an entrepreneur working at the intersection of AI and public education, believes this is an important concern, but an incomplete one. According to him, India must separate two very different conversations: teaching children how to use AI, and using AI to teach children who otherwise have no access to personalised academic support.



Q1. The most common concern parents have today is that AI may make children intellectually lazy. Do you agree?

A: It is a valid concern, but it is not the full picture. For children who already have access to good schools, educated parents, private tutors and learning resources, overdependence on AI is a real risk. If a child uses AI only to skip thinking, write essays without understanding them or get instant answers without struggle, that can weaken learning. But that is one part of India. There is another, much larger India where the problem is not that AI is answering too many questions. The problem is that no one is answering those questions at all. So before asking “Is AI making children lazy?”, we need to ask, “Which children are we talking about?”

Q2. What do you think is missing from India's current AI-in-education debate?

A: We are mixing up two very different ideas. The first is teaching children to use AI. That includes AI literacy, prompt writing, coding, responsible use and critical thinking around technology. This is important because every child will grow up in a world shaped by AI. The second is using AI to teach children. That means using AI-backed systems to provide personalised, patient, always-available academic support to students who may otherwise never receive one-on-one attention. The first is a skill for tomorrow. The second is a solution for today. India is talking loudly about the first. We are not talking enough about the second.

Q3. Why is personalised attention so central to learning outcomes?

A: Every parent knows this intuitively. When a child is stuck, what changes everything is not always a new textbook or a new classroom. Often, it is one teacher who sits with them, explains patiently, and does not move on until they understand. For decades, this has been the invisible advantage of India's middle-class and upper-middle-class households. A private teacher, tuition support, an older sibling, or a parent who can help after school. But millions of children in Government schools do not have that safety net. Many are first-generation learners. Many study in crowded classrooms. Many return home to environments where there may be no one who can help them with Science, Maths or English. For these students, personalised teaching is not a luxury. It is the missing foundation.

Q4. So when you say AI can help, you are not talking about AI as a shortcut?

A: Not at all. The worst use of AI in education is to make it an answer machine. The best use is to make it a patient learning companion. A child should not simply receive the answer. The child should be guided towards understanding. The system should identify where the child is stuck, explain the concept differently, ask follow-up questions, and support the student at their pace. The real promise of AI is not that it can replace thinking. The promise is that it can create the conditions in which many more children get to think seriously for the first time.

Q5. What does this mean specifically for Government school students?

A: For a Government school student in a remote district, AI can mean something very different from what it means to an urban child using ChatGPT for homework. It can mean access to a teacher at 10 pm before an exam. It can mean being able to ask the same question five times without embarrassment. It can mean getting help in a subject

where no one at home can support them. It can mean that the child does not have to give up just because the classroom bell has rung. That is a very powerful shift.

Q6. Critics may say technology alone cannot fix education. How do you respond?

A: They are right. Technology alone cannot fix education. But technology can extend the reach of good pedagogy. It can support teachers, not replace them. It can help districts identify learning gaps. It can make academic support available beyond school hours. It can give students continuity. The mistake is to imagine AI as a silver bullet. It is not. But when used thoughtfully, with district ownership, school participation and strong implementation, it can become a very serious public education tool.

Q7. Have you seen evidence that this kind of intervention works?

A: Yes, and some of the most important evidence is coming from Government school systems where we have seen this model operate at district scale. Through programmes like Sampurna Shiksha Kavach in Jharkhand, the core idea has been to give Government school students access to personalised academic support beyond the limits of the classroom. Not as a replacement for school or teachers, but as an additional layer of help for the child who gets stuck after school hours and has no one at home to turn to. The outcomes are worth paying attention to. In Gumla, the Class 12 Science pass percentage rose from 50.2% to 91%. In West Singhbhum, also known as Chaibasa, schools under this intervention recorded an 87.9% pass rate, compared to 73% in non-intervention schools in the same district. At the school level, CM SOE Tatanagar in Chaibasa moved from 25% to 92% in 2026. For me, the significance of these numbers is not just the improvement itself. It is what they reveal about the missing piece in public education.

Q8. Is there a risk that AI will widen inequality instead of reducing it?

A: Absolutely, if access remains unequal. If AI becomes another paid advantage available only to privileged households, it will widen the gap. But if AI-backed teaching is made available through public systems, especially to Government school students, it can do the opposite. This is why the policy question matters.

Q9. What role should teachers play in an AI-enabled education system?

A: Teachers become even more important. AI can handle repetition, immediate support and personalised practice. But teachers bring context, motivation, trust, discipline, emotional intelligence and classroom leadership.

Q10. What should India's real question on AI and education be?

A: For India, the most powerful use of AI in education may not be teaching privileged children how to prompt better. It may be giving an underserved child, sitting alone with a textbook, the first real chance to ask, understand and continue learning. That is the debate we should be having.

(PNS)

(Rohit Kr Garg is the Co-founder of Filo. An IIT Kharagpur Computer Science graduate and former Microsoft professional, he works at the intersection of artificial intelligence, personalised learning and public education systems in India)

How AI is giving Indians the right to learn their own language



DR BUDDHA CHANDRASEKHAR

India is fundamentally a landscape of voices. According to the 2011 Census, our nation boasts 22 Scheduled Languages and a staggering 1,369 rationalised mother tongues. This breathtaking diversity is our greatest cultural asset. Yet for decades, a silent paradox has lingered beneath the surface. The architecture of our higher education, legal systems, and modern digital economy has rested almost entirely on an English foundation. English is recorded as the mother tongue of just 0.02% of Indians, which is approximately 260,000 people in a nation of 1.4 billion. Even accounting for those who use it as a second or third language, nearly 90% of the country remains outside the English-speaking umbrella. This is not merely an inconvenience. It is a structural injustice that systematically disconnects millions of brilliant minds from the knowledge systems they need to flourish.

The digital age has only sharpened this crisis. According to the Internet in India Report 2024, jointly published by the Internet and Mobile Association of India (IAMAI) and Kantar, 98% of India's 886 million internet users access content in Indic languages. This report is India's most comprehensive annual digital survey and covers over 90,000 households across all states. Furthermore, 57% of urban internet users actively prefer regional language content over English. Yet the supply side tells a starkly different story. Data from web-analytics firm W3Techs, analysed by Rest of World, reveals that Hindi accounts for just 0.07% of global web domains, despite being the most spoken language in India. Meanwhile, languages like Bengali and Urdu, each spoken by hundreds of millions, are described



as “nearly impossible to find online.” Every year, capable students drift away from technical education. This happens not for lack of intellect, but because the medium of instruction is foreign to them. Millions of citizens cannot access legal rights, welfare schemes, or healthcare information simply because the paperwork is unreadable to them.

The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 took an honest, courageous step toward solving this by prioritising mother-tongue education. However, policy without a technological engine remains an unfulfilled aspiration. Artificial Intelligence is finally giving us the cognitive infrastructure required to turn this policy into a living reality.

At the Anuvadini Foundation (Anuvadini AI), a Section 8 company under the AICTE, Ministry of Education, Government of India, our focus has been to deploy advanced AI as a public good that restores linguistic dignity at scale. The results are already measurable. Our platform has processed over 150 crore pages through its translation engine. It also maintains a repository of over 870 domain-specific dictionaries to ensure technical and contextual accuracy.



Furthermore, we translated more than 700 NCERT textbooks and 721 NIMI skill-development books into regional languages within a span of three months.

This work has been formalized through an active collaboration with the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT), India's apex body for school curriculum. This partnership is specifically focused on translating NCERT's foundational textbooks and learning materials into India's Scheduled Languages. NCERT's curriculum serves over 250 million school children. When this content becomes accessible in languages like Odia, Maithili, Santali, and Dogri, the impact is genuinely generational. Our partnership with NCERT represents precisely what NEP 2020 envisioned. It is not just a policy aspiration sitting in a gazette notification, but a working technological pipeline delivering mother-tongue education to classrooms today.

To dismantle an institutional barrier, technology must operate at a systemic scale. Our bulk-translation tool Bujji, which translates directly within formats like InDesign, CorelDraw, PPT, Photoshop, etc, demonstrates this by rendering thousands of pages of complex engineering, medical, and legal texts into regional languages without losing formatting or contextual meaning. In Kerala, over 5,136 district court judgments have been translated into Malayalam. This makes justice readable in the language of the people it serves. Our real-time multilingual translation and transcription tool redefines communication further. It accepts spoken regional dialects for up to 47 minutes and delivers instant contextual translation, enabling seamless interaction between citizens and institutions across linguistic divides.

Anuvadini AI has translated the websites of Shri Ram Janmabhoomi, Incredible India, and Rashtrapati Bhawan. The scope of Anuvadini AI's institutional partnerships continues to expand. A recent Memorandum of Understanding with the Central Council for Research in Ayurvedic Sciences (CCRAS), Ministry of Ayush,

focuses on translating research publications, the CCRAS Bulletin, and Information, Education, and Communication (IEC) materials into 13 regional languages. This ensures that authentic, research-backed Ayurveda knowledge reaches citizens in their native tongue and reduces the spread of misinformation in the health space.

Technology must also address digital sovereignty. As hundreds of millions of regional language speakers enter the digital space, they require secure, encrypted frameworks that protect their privacy. Our platform, Hyped Samvadini, a super global communication app, embeds multilingual translation directly into a SIM-binding, end-to-end encrypted messaging environment. This protects vulnerable populations, particularly women and senior citizens, from identity theft and financial fraud while enabling natural communication in their mother tongue.

National competitive examinations, including JEE, NEET, and CUET, are now increasingly available in regional languages through our infrastructure. This ensures that students are judged on their mastery of the subject, not their command of English. These are not isolated applications. They are the building blocks of an inclusive knowledge society, one where technology functions as a public utility rather than a corporate product.

The transformation is no longer a distant projection. It is visible today in the engineering colleges of Odisha, the courtrooms of Kerala, and the school classrooms where a child is reading an NCERT textbook in the language their mother speaks at home. India has always spoken in many voices. By deploying AI as an equaliser, we are finally building institutions with the capacity to listen to all of them.

The writer is the CEO of the Anuvadini Foundation and the CCO of the AICTE, Ministry of Education, Government of India.

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Supreme Court AI rules: The hidden hypocrisy of India's tech boom

Supreme Court bans AI for judges: Why the public is still trapped in the machine



NISHANT SAHDEV

Washington, DC — India is entering a technological utopia. In the first half of 2026, a wave of capital has flooded our tech sector. The government just announced a \$1.1 billion venture fund for AI. The Adani Group has committed \$100 billion to build AI data centres. Planning started for Smart Borders, Blackstone just dropped \$600 million on a single Indian AI startup, Neysa.

But if you look closely at what these billions of dollars are actually building, a much darker picture emerges.

In a nicely written book of year 2018, Automating Inequality, Virginia Eubanks warned us that when massive institutions digitise, they don't democratise. Instead, they build a “digital poorhouse” — a system where the wealthy use technology to make their lives easier, while the working class is managed, and denied essential services by algorithms.

Eight years later, Eubanks' warning isn't just coming true. It is the foundational business model of the 2026 Indian tech boom. We aren't funding a utopian future; we are funding the mass automation of the middle and lower classes. We are building a new socioeconomic divide where human empathy, and attention are entirely eradicated for the public, and reserved exclusively as a luxury good for the rich.

The Supreme Court's Accidental Confession

If you want undeniable proof of this emerging class system, look no further than the preliminary draft of the Regulations for Use of Artificial Intelligence in Courts, 2026, released just days ago on June 3 by the Supreme Court of India.

It is a piece of regulatory foresight. The apex court explicitly banned the use of AI for determining judicial outcomes, bail eligibility, or sentencing.

They specifically prohibited the use of “black-box” risk-scoring algorithms. The mandate is clear: AI must remain strictly subservient to human judgment. The court recognized a truth — human lives are too messy, context is too vital, and justice is too complex to be outsourced to code.

The judges are entirely right. But their ruling exposes a maddening hypocrisy.

The highest echelons of power just legally protected themselves, and the citizens for-



tunate enough to reach their courtrooms, from the unfeeling judgment of the machine. Yet, outside the halls of the Supreme Court, those exact same “black-box” algorithms — fuelled by this new wave of billion-dollar venture funding — are currently running wild through the daily lives of the Indian public.

Why is human context a fundamental legal right in a bail hearing, but an unaffordable luxury when an enterprise AI system filters your resume, denies your health insurance claim, or rejects your micro-loan? When a human bank manager says no, you can plead your case, provide context, or point out a clerical error. When an algorithm says no, you are simply rejected by an invisible math equation.

The elite have legally protected themselves from the machine. The rest of the country is being pushed inside it.

The End of the 'Hold Music' Era

Venture capital does not flow to democratic society; it flows to maximize efficiency. And in corporate India today, the greatest “efficiency” to be gained is the total eradication of human payroll.

We are currently witnessing the death of human-to-human corporate interaction. For years, consumers complained about the frustration of sitting on hold for forty-five minutes just to dispute a fraudulent bank

charge or fix a delayed flight. Very soon, we are going to miss the hold music.

The startups currently digesting hundreds of millions in funding are not building tools to help you. They are building digital moats for mega-corporations. The enterprise chatbots of 2026 are impeccably polite, grammatically perfect, and functionally useless for edge cases. They are programmed to simulate empathy while protecting the company's bottom line. They will apologise for your broken product in a dozen different lyrical variations, but they will not authorise your refund.

The cost of human labor is high, and the cost of AI compute is plunging toward zero. For a telecom giant or a massive e-commerce platform, the goal is no longer customer service. The goal is to make reaching a human employee so exhausting, so labyrinthine, and so frustrating that the consumer simply gives up. We are digitising apathy. Corporations are using their newly funded AI not to solve our problems, but to scale their own indifference to infinite proportions.

'Human' is the New Organic

To understand exactly how this new class divide will look, we only need to look at what happened to the global food industry over the last century. Decades ago, heavily processed, scientifically optimized food was marketed as a modern miracle. It was cheap, it was efficient, and it fed the masses. Fast forward to today, and the script has completely flipped. Processed, mass-produced food is the default diet of the working class, while the wealthy pay astronomical premiums for food that is “organic,” “hand-picked,” and “farm-to-table.”

Industrialisation made the artificial cheap, which inherently made the natural a luxury. AI is simply the industrialisation of thought. It is processed intelligence.

In the very near future, these highly funded AI services will be pushed onto the public as a great equaliser. On the surface, it will look like progress. But it will be a hollowed-out version of the services the wealthy receive. An AI tutor will never recognise that a student is failing because they are hungry or being bullied at home. An AI therapist will dispense perfectly optimised cognitive behavioural prompts, but it will never actually care if the patient lives or dies.

Meanwhile, the wealthy will opt out. They will send their children to screen-free schools with human teachers. They will consult human doctors who have the time to listen to their fears. They will hire human wealth managers who understand the subtle art of negotiation.

The phrase “Talk to a real person” is changing from a basic consumer expectation into a premium subscription tier. The ultimate status symbol in 2028 won't be a sports car; it will be a company guaranteeing an “Artisanal Human Experience” — a real expert whose time you can actually afford to buy.

The Right to a Human

As we celebrate the billions dollars flowing into data centers, we must ask: efficiency for whom? When welfare benefits, identity verification, and municipal complaints are entirely automated, the vulnerable fall through the cracks. Eubanks warned us that technology allows institutions to hide their cruelty behind a veneer of objective math.

We don't just need regulations that demand tech platforms delete deepfakes in three hours. We don't just need the Supreme Court to exempt itself from AI judgments. We need protections for the everyday consumer who is currently in the crosshairs of this massive funding boom. If a machine denies you a job, terminates your insurance, flags your tax return, or rejects your Government benefits, you must have the legal right to force a human being to look you in the eye and explain why. We need to legally enshrine a “Right to a Human” before the architecture of this new class system hardens permanently.

Tech billionaires love to tell us that their AI models will elevate humanity. But if we aren't careful, humanity itself will become just another luxury good — priced out of reach for everyone except those who can afford the artisanal experience of being treated like a person.

The writer is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a columnist on AI, infrastructure and global systems

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Viyash Scientific acquires Italy’s BioForLife

City-based Viyash Scientific Limited, through its wholly owned subsidiary Alivira Animal Health Limited, has signed an agreement to acquire 100 per cent stake in Italy-based BioForLife, a pet care company.

The ₹188 crore acquisition is expected to close in Q2 FY27, Viyash Scientific Limited said in a release here on Monday. The transaction represents a significant step in Viyash’s strategy to capitalise on the mega-trend of a growing Companion Animal Health Generics market, it said. It expands Alivira’s global Companion Animal Health business and strengthens its presence in the European pet care market.

BioForLife (BFL), based in Milan, Italy, specialises in the development, commercialisation, and distribution of pet care products.

The acquisition will provide Viyash Scientific Limited, a platform for launching new products from Alivira’s pipeline in Italy, while simultaneously providing opportunities to expand the BFL range to other markets in the Alivira group located in Europe, the Middle East, Asia and Latin America.

Commenting on the acquisition, Viyash Scientific Limited Managing Director and Group CEO Haribabu Bodeputi said: “This acquisition represents another important step in our strategy to build a leading global Companion Animal Health business. BioForLife provides us with an established platform in Italy, one of Europe’s most attractive pet care markets, while strengthening our presence across the region.”

This transaction also strengthens the Alivira team with the induction of BFL executives who will continue to run the business operations, in addition to driving new growth initiatives, the release added.

(PTI)

BMW India to hike prices by up to 2 pc from July 1

German luxury car maker BMW Group India on Monday said it will increase prices by up to two per cent across its entire BMW and MINI vehicle portfolios with effect from July 1.

The price hike will be applicable across locally-produced as well as completely-built-up BMW and MINI brands, the company said in a statement.

“To protect our premium standards against macroeconomic headwinds – specifically rupee depreciation and escalating logistics costs – we are introducing a price increase of up to 2 per cent across our portfolio, effective July 1,” said Hardeep Singh Brar, President and CEO, BMW Group India.

BMW India’s range of locally produced cars includes the 2 Series Gran Coupe, 3 Series Long Wheelbase, 5 Series Long Wheelbase, 7 Series, X1, X3, X5, X7, M340i and iX1 Long Wheelbase models.

Besides, it also offers i5 M60, i7, i7 M70, BMW iX, M440i Convertible, M2 Coupe, M4 Competition, M5 and XM as completely built-up units (CBU).

(PTI)

Dealers see surge in inquiries for green vehicles post fuel-price hike: FADA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The fuel price hikes in May saw a noticeable shift in consumer interest towards fuel-efficient and alternative-powertrain vehicles, with dealers reporting a surge in inquiries for such models and electric two-wheeler penetration rising to 9.25 per cent from 6.11 per cent a year ago, FADA said on Monday.

According to the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA), India’s overall automobile retail sales climbed 9.55 per cent year-on-year to a record 25.31 lakh units.

“A notable feature of the month was the consumer response to the May fuel-price revision: dealers reported a visible rise in enquiries for fuel-efficient and alterna-

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | JUNE 9, 2026

Rajesh exports shares hit lower circuit for third day

Government probing on ₹1,000 worth PLI deal for EV batteries manufacturing

J GOPIKRISHNAN ■ New Delhi

Shares of controversial gems and jewellery firm Rajesh Exports Ltd (REL) hit a fresh lower circuit limit on Monday, tumbling over 14 per cent in the past three days, after the Sebi last week passed an interim order alleging massive financial fraud by the company. The stock tanked 4.98 per cent to hit the lower circuit limit at ₹94.50 on the BSE. At the NSE, the stock dropped 4.99 per cent to hit the lower circuit limit of ₹93.80.

Meanwhile, media reported that The Ministry of Heavy Industries (MHI) headed by Union Minister Kumaraswamy is set to decide in the coming days on removing Rajesh Exports from the list of beneficiaries under the production-linked incentive (PLI) scheme for advanced chemistry cell (ACC) battery storage, after the SEBI last week passed an interim order alleging massive financial fraud by the Bengaluru-based firm. It is learned that Rajesh Exports in 2022, bagged PLI contract for manufacturing EV Batteries contract in India worth more

than ₹1,000 crore worth deal. Sources said, though the company claim the production is create manufacturing India, the major parts of EV Batteries are just imported from China and assemble in Indian factories.

On Monday, ‘The Pioneer’ reported that Rajesh Exports is already facing huge loan recovery suits from Canara Bank from 2020. Controversial businessman Rajesh Mehta led Rajesh Exports, caught recently by Securities Exchange Board of India (SEBI) for inflating the revenue of more than ₹15 lakh crore, is already large defaulter of Canara Bank with more than ₹2,458 crore loan dues.

As per conducting a detailed analysis of the TransUnion CIBIL data filed by Canara Bank, Rajesh Exports owes a total of ₹2,458 crores and the loan amount is split into six entries of ₹Rs.409 each. Canara Bank is now conducting recovery suits at Debut Recovery Tribunal (DRT) in Chennai and three Directors of the company are shows as personal guarantors to this huge loan. The Directors shown as personal guarantors are Rajesh Mehta and his partners Prashant Mehta and S Pramasivan.

The stock of Rajesh Exports Ltd has tumbled 14.20 per cent on the BSE since June 3, following the SEBI action. The Securities

and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) on June 3 barred Rajesh Exports promoter and CEO Rajesh Mehta from dealing in the company’s securities, alleging large-scale misrepresentation of financial statements and diversion of funds. In a 109-page interim order, the regulator found Rajesh Exports allegedly inflated its consolidated revenues by more than ₹15 lakh crore over five years by attributing massive revenues to overseas subsidiaries, particularly Valcambi SA, despite the subsidiary’s audited stand-alone financial statements showing only a fraction of those amounts.

Interestingly, Canara Bank has not approached CBI or ED for cheating against Rajesh Exports and its Directors, though it filed a civil recovery case of just ₹452 crore in 2021. Rajesh Exports which now caught by SEBI for inflated revenue of ₹15 lakh crore also filed a counter case in DRT against the bank, seeking loss of more than ₹20,456 crore. However DRT in 2023, has dismissed the fake claim of Rajesh Exports, citing that they have produced fake bills.

SpiceJet to induct 3 Airbus A320 planes on damp lease in July

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Domestic carrier Spicejet on Monday said it plans to induct three Airbus A320 planes on a damp lease next month to further expand its fleet.

The company has already finalised a lease agreement (with the lessor) for these three narrowbody planes,

the airline said in a statement. Along with this, Spicejet said it has also ungrounded a Boeing 737 MAX aircraft and put it back into commercial operations.

The additional capacity will support the airline’s network requirements during the busy travel season and provide greater operational flexibility across its domestic and

international routes, it said. “These aircraft will help us meet growing passenger

demand, strengthen operational resilience and enhance network flexibility during a busy travel period,” said Debojo Maharshi, Chief Business Officer, Spicejet.

The airline, he said, continues to focus on steadily expanding its fleet and improving operational readiness as we move forward with our growth plans.

India gets EU approval to export aquaculture products

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The European Union (EU) has included India in the list of countries authorised to continue exporting aquaculture products, eggs, honey and animal casings to the 27-nation bloc beyond September under its revised regulatory framework.

The commerce ministry on Monday said that the European Union has notified an amendment to Regulation (EU) 2021/405 in view of growing concerns over antimicrobial resistance. The revised regula-

tion will come into effect from September 2026 and lays down additional requirements for countries exporting specified animal-origin products to the European Union (EU).

India’s inclusion in the list of authorised countries ensures continuity of exports of these products to the European Union market beyond September 2026, the ministry said. This is particularly significant for the fisheries sector, as exports of fish and fishery products from India to the EU are currently valued at about \$1.59 billion.

BHAVYA scheme to attract investments, jobs: Goyal

PNS ■ New Delhi

The ₹33,660 crore Bharat Audyogik Vikas Yojna (BHAVYA) scheme will help attract huge investments, create jobs, and provide modern social infrastructure in the 100 industrial parks to be developed under this initiative, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Monday.

On March 18, the Union Cabinet approved the scheme for developing 100 plug-and-play industrial parks across the country.

It aims to develop world-class industrial infrastructure, unlock manufacturing

potential and drive the country’s economic growth. “We want to make sure that the scheme does become the change agent in terms of promoting invest-

ments across India in industry. “We can see a lot of interest from industry already and I do believe that the ₹34,000 crore that the Government is earmarking for these 100

industrial parks in a plug and play mode will help catalyse large amount of investments, create significant jobs, provide modern social infra on these parks, and demonstrate centre-state partnership as its best,” Goyal said here while launching a portal to roll out the scheme.

Applicants can submit their applications through the portal. The scheme will adopt a competitive model under which states will be encouraged to submit detailed project proposals highlighting their industrial strengths, availability of land, investor interest, and sectoral potential.

Capital markets becoming key avenue for household savings: SEBI chief

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Capital markets are increasingly emerging as a core avenue for household savings and wealth creation in India, reflecting a structural shift in how Indians are investing and participating in the country’s growth story, SEBI Chairperson Tuhin Kant Pandey said on Monday.

“Capital markets are increasingly becoming a core avenue for household savings and wealth creation,” Pandey said at the ICICI Securities India Investor Conference 2026. On the Portfolio Management Services (PMS)

regulations, the SEBI chief indicated that extensive deliberations are underway and a consultation paper will be released soon. However, he declined to specify a timeline.

Pandey said India’s economic rise is not only about higher growth numbers but also about the formalisation of the economy, financialisation of savings and growing trust in institutions.

Highlighting the growing depth of Indian markets, Pandey said the country now has around 145 million investors in the securities market, with the investor base expanding at more than 20 per cent annually.

He noted that mutual fund assets have surged from about ₹12 lakh crore to over ₹80 lakh crore over the years, while household participa-

tion in capital markets has continued to rise steadily.

Pandey said household financial savings as a share of GDP increased to 21.7 per

cent in FY25 from around 20 per cent in FY23, aided by broader participation across financial instruments.

“Together, these developments point to a clear shift,” Pandey said, adding that households are increasingly allocating savings towards market-linked investment avenues.

The SEBI chief said India’s capital markets are not merely reflecting the country’s growth but are actively enabling it by connecting household savings with enterprises, attracting global capital and converting economic momentum into investable opportunities.

He said equity issuances touched ₹4.5 lakh crore in FY26, while 366 IPOs raised around ₹1.9 lakh crore during the year. Corporate bond issuances exceeded ₹9 lakh crore, underscoring the growing role of markets in capital formation.

Market capitalisation has risen from about 69 per cent of GDP a decade ago to nearly 128 per cent currently, despite recent market corrections, he said. Pandey said the broadening investor base places greater responsibility on regulators and market intermediaries to ensure transparency, investor protection and market integrity.

Adani Ports bags 10-year contract for Argentina’s first LNG export project

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Ltd (APSEZ) on Monday said it has secured a 10-year marine services contract for Argentina’s first Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG) export, marking its entry into South America and expanding its international marine services footprint.

The company in a statement said the contract has been awarded to APSEZ’s step-down subsidiary, Adani Harbour International FZCO, through a consortium with

Argentina-based Meridian Group, following a global competitive tender process conducted by Southern Energy SA (SESA). The award strengthens

APSEZ’s presence across international energy logistics value chains and underscores its growing capabilities in specialised marine services, it added.

Union Minister Nitin Gadkari addressing the launch of Rapido and MoRTH Road Safety Partnership for Rahveer Scheme under Sadak Suraksha Abhiyan in New Delhi

PTI

Road safety is shared responsibility: Gadkari

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Road safety is a shared responsibility and citizen’s participation is critical in reducing fatalities on India’s road, Union minister Nitin Gadkari said on Monday, stressing that changing public behaviour and enforcing traffic laws remain the country’s biggest challenges in improving road safety.

Addressing an event organised by mobility platform Rapido, Gadkari said India records nearly 5 lakh road accidents and 1.80 lakh fatalities annually.

“Road safety is a shared responsibility and citizen participation is critical to reducing fatalities on our roads...Our biggest problem is changing public behaviour and enforcing traffic laws,” he said.

The number of road accident fatalities in India went up by 2.3 per cent to over 1.77 lakh in 2024, resulting in the deaths of 485 persons every day.

A total number of 4,80,583 road accidents have been reported by the police departments of states and Union Territories (UTs) in the country during the calendar

year 2023, claiming 1,72,890 lives and causing injuries to 4,62,825 persons.

“Through the Rahveer Scheme, we seek to encourage individuals to assist accident victims without hesitation and help save lives during the Golden Hour,” the road transport and highways minister said.

During a road accident, every second matters, especially in the critical ‘Golden Hour’, when timely help can save a life. To support and protect those who step forward in such moments, the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways notified the Good Samaritan Rules in 2020 under Section 134A of the Motor Vehicles (Amendment) Act, 2019.

The ‘Rah-Veer’ (Good Samaritan) Scheme also offers financial recognition and celebrates these individuals as real-life heroes who chose compassion over hesitation.

Under the scheme, anyone who helps an accident victim receive medical attention within the Golden Hour is eligible for a ₹25,000 reward and a Certificate of Appreciation, with recognition available up to five times a year for repeat acts of bravery.

PROSPECT

58 crore Jan Dhan accounts bring Indians to formal banking system: FM



Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman receives a dividend cheque of ₹8,813 crore for FY 2025-26 from CS Setty, Chairman, State Bank of India; Secretary, Department of Financial Services was present on the occasion on Monday

PIONEER PHOTO

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Monday said that over 58 crore Jan Dhan accounts have brought crores of Indians into the formal banking system.

The Jan Dhan scheme has ensured that benefits under welfare schemes, low-cost insurance, and pensions reach without leakages, the Finance Minister's office said in a post on X.

"Garib Kalyan is Hon'ble PM Shri @narendramodi's guarantee of dignity, opportunity and empowerment for every Indian," she said.

India has stood out globally in its fight against poverty and deprivation, she added.

Launched on August 28, 2014, Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY) is one of the world's largest financial inclusion initiatives.

Fifty-six per cent of the PMJDY account holders are women, while 67 per cent of accounts are opened in rural and semi-urban areas.

As much as Rs 45 lakh crore was transferred directly to beneficiary accounts through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT).

Ninety-four per cent of India's adult population has a bank account now.

Accounts opened under the scheme offer a zero balance facility, free RuPay cards, accidental insurance, and an overdraft facility.

(PNS)

Parents call screen time waste; Gen Z finds comfort in it: Survey

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The student-led study conducted by communications firm 80dB, suggests the real divide is not whether young people are online, but how adults and teens interpret the same digital habits. The survey, titled More Than Screen Time: What Gen Z and Gen Alpha Wish Adults Understood, covered 130 young people aged 13-16 and more than 100 parents in Gurugram.

It found that 93 per cent of young respondents use online platforms to talk to friends, while 82 per cent said adults assume they are wasting time online. Nearly 8 in 10 parents said they were concerned about their child's screen use, and 65 per cent believed children online are mostly distracted by reels, shorts and chatting.

The findings push back against the familiar stereotype of Gen Z as merely dis-



tracted or addicted to screens. Young respondents said they also use the internet for schoolwork, learning new skills, listening to music, relaxing after school and self-expression. At the same time, they were not blindly optimistic: 71 per cent said spending more time online than planned is a negative, and 62 per cent cited comparison with others as a downside.

One of the strongest signals from the survey was emotional rather than digital. 52 per cent of young respondents said adults think young

people are lazy, but many are actually overwhelmed, while 83 per cent cited exams and studies as a major source of pressure. Parents broadly agreed that pressure is real, with 77 per cent saying young people today are under a lot of stress.

The report also highlights a privacy and trust gap between parents and children. 66 per cent of young respondents said they want privacy, not constant monitoring, while 65 per cent of parents said their concern comes from wanting to keep children safe.

Assam Governor pays tribute to martyrs at Amar Shaheed Shradhanjali Programme in Guwahati

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Assam Governor Lakshman Prasad Acharya on Sunday attended the "Amar Shaheed Shradhanjali" programme organised by the Directorate of Sainik Welfare, Assam, at the Assam State War Memorial in Dighalipukhuri and Don Bosco High School in Panbazar, Guwahati, to honour soldiers from the state who laid down their lives in service of the nation.

Paying homage to the martyrs, the Governor said the nation remains forever indebted to its brave sons and daughters who made the supreme sacrifice while safeguarding the country's sovereignty and integrity. He noted that the Indian Armed Forces continue to uphold the highest traditions of courage, discipline and dedication while protecting the nation across diverse and challenging terrains.

Referring to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's observation that the armed forces safeguard not only the



nation's borders but also the aspirations and future of its people, Acharya said India's soldiers embody the country's strength, character and unwavering resolve.

As part of the programme, six Veer Naris paid floral tributes to their husbands who were martyred in the line of duty.

The Governor interacted with them and expressed the nation's gratitude for their courage, resilience and sacrifice. He said their strength and devotion serve as a lasting inspiration for society.

The event brought together veterans, serving defence personnel, NCC cadets and students, who joined in remembering Assam's fallen heroes.

The Governor called upon citizens to reaffirm their commitment to national unity and support the welfare and dignity of martyrs' families, describing it as the most meaningful tribute to the nation's immortal heroes.

Among those present at the programme were Lieutenant General Rana Pratap Kalita (Retd.), former

Radio Highway Pallel inspires youth through stories of local achievers

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Radio Highway Pallel, the community radio station established at the Pallel Garrison of Assam Rifles, is emerging as a platform for youth empowerment by showcasing the success stories of distinguished personalities from Manipur who have made their mark on national and international stages.

Through a series of inspirational programmes, the station is promoting constructive dialogue on peace, development, prosperity and progress while encouraging young people to pursue excellence in their chosen fields. The initiative aims to motivate the region's youth by highlighting the achievements of homegrown talents who have overcome challenges to achieve success.

Following the recent broadcast featuring renowned Manipuri astro-



physicist Dr Ronaldo Laishram, Radio Highway Pallel has recorded a special podcast with Mixed Martial Arts (MMA) star Chungreng Koren. Popularly known as "The Indian Rhino," Koren has represented India at various national and international competitions and recently gained recognition for his advancement in the prestigious Road to UFC tournament.

The podcast, scheduled to be released on June 11, will provide listeners with an insight into Koren's journey in professional MMA. During the session, he

shares the challenges he faced in his career and emphasizes the importance of discipline, perseverance, determination and hard work in achieving success.

According to the organisers, the programme seeks to draw a common thread between achievers from diverse fields, demonstrating how dedication and resilience can help local talent reach global platforms. By bringing such stories directly to the public, the station hopes to inspire young people across Manipur to dream big and work towards their goals.

Udalguri school felicitates Agnipath recruits, trainers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Udalguri

A felicitation ceremony was held at Udalguri Higher Secondary School on Friday to honour young recruits selected for the Indian Army under the Agnipath Scheme and recognize the efforts of the training teams that guided them through the recruitment process.

The event was organised by local civil society groups in collaboration with the civil administration and was attended by BTR Deputy Chief Executive Member Rihon Daimari as the chief guest. The ceremony highlighted the Indian Army's outreach efforts aimed at encouraging and preparing Bodo youth for a career in the armed forces.

Addressing the gathering, Daimari lauded the dedication of the Army's training teams and their role in shaping the future of aspiring candidates. He said such initiatives not only provide employment opportunities for local youth but also contribute significantly to nation-building and national security.

As part of its recruitment outreach programme, the Indian Army conducted extensive awareness campaigns in schools and colleges across the region, reaching more than 2,000 students from 30 educational institutions.

The initiative began with a pre-recruitment rally held on November 23, 2024, to identify and prepare potential candidates for the recruitment process.



DAILY SUDOKU

	5			4			8	7
1		2	8	3				4
						1	6	
	3	7		2		5	1	
			8	9				
7								
				6	2	8		5
5	8		1				7	

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

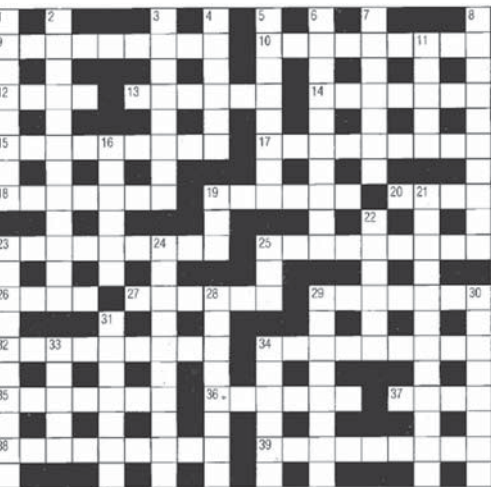
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (8.6.26)								
9	2	8	6	3	7	5	1	4
7	1	6	4	5	2	8	9	3
4	3	5	9	1	8	7	2	6
2	6	9	1	7	3	4	5	8
3	8	4	5	9	6	2	7	1
1	5	7	8	2	4	6	3	9
8	9	1	7	6	5	3	4	2
6	7	3	2	4	1	9	8	5
5	4	2	3	8	9	1	6	7

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
TUESDAY | JUNE 9, 2026



ACROSS

- Listen. The two men are moving (4,2,3)
- I near got sent off - seriously (2,7)
- Spells "paroxysms" (4)
- Thought it had got back in time (6)
- With scorn said "Awful racket outside"
- A flash and the light's going on and off
- Cruel as the ingrate Frenchman? (9)
- The springer sprang in the garden! (3,4)
- Or making a comeback in the role of the flier (6)
- Get attached, you say, to the foreigner
- Did it not rise as it should, for the baker? (9)
- How Shakespeare's collaborator worked

DOWN

- Doomed to catch the bug? (3-5)
- No holds barred if there should be an item missing (8,4)
- "Don't forget", says the note, "the increment" (8)
- Their having lost the chess piece is annoying (6)
- Calling a bankrupt "Mr Monies", perhaps?
- The novice is given money at the base? "The doctor act is in need of surgery" is harsh (7)
- Doesn't sit until there's a complete lack of movement (10)
- About a second before, cancel (5)
- Such a problem as granny might become? (6)

happily? (4,1,4)

- Drive off reversing to let us in (4)
- Pass round and see to be bothered about (6)
- Joins in the frenzied cheers when the ball is caught (7)
- Plump up the pillow for the makeshift bed? (9)
- Bedecked, had had it (9)
- Encourage the man - a rent-collector (7)
- This character is no prohibitionist (6)
- Behind one's rival in points, is depressed (4)
- They won't get rid of their servants (9)
- An atheist and treacherous (9)

19 Pastry the half ripe one went into (3)

- You'll get a shock if it works! (4,8)
- The iron and the wood, I myself carried
- Comes to a sudden halt, which prevents electrical trouble (5,5)
- He's more versatile than most and, on the whole, plumper (3-7)
- "Just a minute", said myself and yourself (3)
- Punish when you write a tissue of lies
- Realised she had been trapped by the murderer (6,2)
- In the sea, nudes swimming - foreigners (8)
- Confident that it's unfalling (7)
- A bit to one side (5)
- About to smoke, was made to alight

Free medical camp by Ananda Marga Pracaraka Samgha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

For the welfare of poor, helpless, and underprivileged families, a free medical camp, "Abha Sewa Sadan," was organized in Sector-150, Noida under the auspices of Ananda Marga Pracaraka Samgha, Noida, with the support of RORX Healthcare Noida and REVIVE Dental Care Noida.

The camp was successfully conducted on June 6, 2026, at the Labour Colony, Antriksh Villa, Sector-150, Noida, under the supervision of an experienced team of doctors, including Dr. Aman



Ror, General Physician and Pediatric Specialist; Dr. Shiba Ror, Gynecologist; and Dr. Garima Ranjan, Dental Surgeon.

The camp offered free medical consultations, primary treatment, health

check-ups, blood pressure and blood sugar testing, ECG examinations, distribution of essential medicines, dental check-ups, X-ray services, and tooth extractions. Special emphasis was also placed on promoting awareness regarding health and hygiene.

At the conclusion of the program, Parveer Kumar, Spokesperson of Ananda Marga Pracaraka Samgha, Noida, expressed his gratitude to all the doctors, volunteers, and supporters whose dedication and cooperation made the successful completion of this service project possible.

NHPC celebrates World Environment Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Faridabad

NHPC celebrated World Environment Day 2026 with a series of environmental initiatives across its offices and project locations nationwide, reaffirming its commitment to sustainability and environmental conservation.

The observance was led by Bhupender Gupta, Chairman and Managing Director (CMD), NHPC, at the company's Corporate Office in Faridabad. Gupta inaugurated the celebrations by planting a sapling and launching a plantation drive as part of NHPC's nationwide campaign.

The event formed part of

NHPC's coordinated World Environment Day activities conducted across its Corporate Office, Regional Offices, Power Stations, Projects and other units throughout the country. The initiatives underscored the organization's continued focus on promoting environmental stewardship and sustainable development.

Invitation For Bids (IFB)

The Chief Executive Officer (CEO), Assam Skill University Project (ASUP) cum Registrar, Assam Skill University (ASU) ("the Purchaser") invites online bid from eligible bidders for the below mentioned Packages at Assam Skill University:

#	Package No.	Package Name	Date of Publication	Deadline for Submission	
			Date	Date	Time
1	GS02/ASU/MTC/034 (Lot-2)	Equipment for Non-Traditional Machining Lab	09 June 2026	09 July 2026	14:00 Hours (IST)
2	GS02/ASU/MC/091	Equipment for Thermal Engineering Lab	09 June 2026	09 July 2026	14:00 Hours (IST)

Interested bidders may download and submit their bids electronically using the e-Procurement portal <https://assamtenders.gov.in/>.

DIPR/C/PIO/372/9-Jun-26

Sd/-
CEO, ASUP cum Registrar, ASU

Kumar Shanker takes charge as Managing Director of Indraprastha Gas



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Indraprastha Gas Ltd (IGL), India's largest city gas distributor, said on Monday that Kumar Shanker has assumed charge as its managing director. He succeeds Kamal Kishore Chatiwal, who has returned to parent company GAIL (India) Ltd after a three-year stint.

Shanker, a chemical engineer from BITS Pilani, brings more than three decades of experience in India's oil and gas sector, spanning natural gas processing, petrochemicals, project management, corporate strategy, marketing, regulatory affairs and city gas distribution. IGL said in a statement.

Prior to joining IGL, he served as Managing Director of Maharashtra Natural Gas Ltd (MNGL), where the company emerged as one of India's top-five city gas distributors in terms of growth, profitability and expansion of domestic piped gas infrastructure.

Over a career spanning more than 30 years at GAIL, Shanker held positions across multiple business verticals and locations, including Gujarat, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh and New Delhi, it said.

BRIEFLY

NexGen Vijay Kumar Memorial to celebrate legacy of golf legend



The DP World Professional Golf Tour of India (DP World PGTI) on Monday announced the launch of the inaugural NexGen Vijay Kumar Memorial, dedicated to celebrating the legacy of legendary Indian golfer. Vijay's untimely demise at the age of 57, on April 28 this year, was a great loss to the golfing fraternity in India. The inaugural tournament, the fifth event of the 2026 NexGen season, is scheduled to be held at Lucknow Golf Club, Vijay Kumar's home course, from June 9-11. The tournament serves as glowing tribute to one of Indian golf's most iconic figures and will aim to inspire next generation of golfers through values that defined Vijay Kumar's illustrious career. Vijay Kumar, winner of 2002 Indian Open and a four-time Order of Merit champion on the Indian domestic circuit, was among the most accomplished and respected names in Indian golf. Born in Lucknow on September 29, 1968, Vijay turned professional in 1988. He dominated Indian golf from mid-1990s to early part of next decade winning numerous titles. (PTI)

Wesley out of World Cup with thigh injury, Ederson in



Brazil has made an injury replacement to its World Cup roster less than a week before its first match against Morocco, with right back Wesley out and midfielder Ederson in. The Brazilian soccer confederation said Sunday that Wesley injured a muscle in his left thigh. He left early in the team's friendly game against Egypt on Saturday night in Cleveland, and imaging found it significant enough to knock Wesley out of the World Cup. "Wesley is an athlete loved by the group and will always be considered part of this team that seeks the six-time world championship," the Brazilian confederation said. Ederson, 26, is now set to join the team in the U.S. as part of the 26-player roster. Brazil opens World Cup group play on Saturday in Meadowlands in East Rutherford, New Jersey. Another injury situation is still ongoing with Neymar, who did not travel to Cleveland with rest of the group. (AP)

Iran's World Cup players arrive in Mexico



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Tijuana (Mexico)

Iran's World Cup team arrived in Mexico wearing lapel pins highlighting the victims of a deadly missile strike on an elementary school at the start of the war in the Mideast. The players wore gold-colored pins with the number "168" on their jackets when getting off their plane Sunday in

Tijuana, Mexico. It referred to the people killed, most of them children, when a Feb. 28 strike, likely launched by the U.S., hit the school in Minab in southern Iran. Iran's embassy in Hungary on Monday noted the pins in a social media post with a reference to Minab. The strike on the school, which was close to a Revolutionary Guard base, was previously memorialised by Iran team before a

India signs off Ulaanbaatar Open with 3 golds

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ulaanbaatar

India capped a successful campaign at the Ulaanbaatar Open Senior Ranking Series wrestling tournament with Deepak (61kg), Sagar Jaglan (74kg) and Dinesh (125kg) winning gold medals in the men's freestyle event on the final day of the competition here. Their stellar performances on Sunday helped India collect seven medals in men's freestyle and take their overall tally to 17 medals across freestyle, Greco-Roman and women's wrestling, ensuring a top-three finish in the team standings. Deepak clinched the 61kg title with a commanding 6-0 victory over Kazakhstan's Assyl Aitakyn,



while heavyweight Dinesh edged Kazakhstan's Yedige Kassimbek 2-0 in the 125kg final. Sagar produced a gritty effort to beat Russia's Tamir Eshinimaev 3-2 and secure the 74kg gold medal. India's freestyle wrestlers also added four bronze medals through Sumit (57kg), Kumar Mohit (65kg), Jaideep (74kg) and Vicky (97kg) and finished runner-up in team championship behind Russia. "The phenomenal success of our freestyle squad in securing the runner-up position, coupled with our Greco-Roman team clinching the overall championship, is a historic milestone for Indian wrestling," Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) president Sanjay Singh said.

"Winning 17 medals against world-class competition highlights the competitive depth of our athletes in the continental space," he added. Earlier, India's Greco-Roman wrestlers had finished their campaign with two gold medals through Sunil (87kg) and Nitesh (97kg), while Sahil secured a bronze in the 60kg category. The Greco-Roman team went on to claim the overall team title with 119 points. The women's contingent contributed seven medals to India's tally, led by gold-medal performances from Manisha (57kg), Neha (59kg) and Kajal (76kg). Neelam (50kg), Hansika Lamba (55kg), Mansi (62kg) and Priya (76kg) added bronze medals.

New-look Indian team begins Asian Games build-up at Archery World Cup in Turkey



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Antalya (Turkey)

India will begin their preparations for the upcoming Asian Games with a completely revamped squad taking the field at the Archery World Cup Stage 3 beginning at Antalya on Tuesday. The biggest talking point is the absence of star archer Deepika Kumari from the recurve women's team event, barely a month after she spearheaded India's stunning World Cup gold medal triumph in Shanghai, where the team upset Olympic champions South Korea and hosts China en route to the title. Following the Shanghai World Cup, the Archery Association of India (AAI) conducted selection trials for World Cup Stages 3 and 4 as well as the Asian Games. The trials produced several surprises, with Deepika, her Olympian husband Atanu Das and reigning Asian Games compound champion Ojas Deotale all missing out on the top-three spots. With only three archers allowed per category at the Asian Games, Deepika and Atanu finished fourth



in their respective trials. While they remain part of the World Cup squads as fourth members, they will not be eligible to compete in team events. In a significant change, the AAI has decided that the fourth-ranked archer will not be considered for team events during the World Cup season, irrespective of the qualification scores. Earlier, the top three archers after the qualification rounds formed the team. But with only three athletes permitted at the Asian Games, the federation wants the designated trio to "build combinations and chemistry well in advance". "This is a new rule that will be in place in this World Cup so that there is team bonding and chemistry among the three members who will compete at Asian Games," an AAI official said. As a result, Deepika and Atanu will only compete in individual events in Antalya, even if they top the trials. For Deepika, it is another setback in an otherwise illustrious career. The four-time Olympian lost a shoot-off to her Jharkhand teammate Ankita Bhakat for the third and final Asian Games spot behind teenagers Kirti Sharma and Kumkum Mohod. One of India's most decorated archers with multiple World Cup and Commonwealth Games medals, Deepika has endured heartbreak at both the Olympics and Asian Games. She is yet to win an Olympic medal despite four appearances and has only one Asian Games medal — a team bronze from Guangzhou way back in 2010. Her absence from the team event will be keenly felt. In Shanghai, Deepika's experience proved invaluable as she guided and mentored younger teammates Kumkum and Ankita during India's first World Cup gold medal in women's recurve team competition since 2021.



Rahi on top, Manu second in women's 25m pistol T4 finals

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dehradun

Former Asian Games champion Rahi Sarnobat produced a commanding performance to win the women's 25m pistol finals, outwitting double Olympic-medallist Manu Bhaker in the National Selection Trials 4 being organised to finalise India's Asian Games shooting squad here on Monday. Rahi, an Olympian, looked in control throughout final and finished with 37 hits to take the top spot. Bhaker settled for silver with 35 hits, while Karnataka's Divya TS claimed bronze with 29 hits.

Tamil Nadu's Niveditha V Nair finished fourth with 24 hits, while Olympian Rhythm Sangwan was fifth with 22 hits. Punjab's Arshdeep Kaur finished sixth with 18 hits, stated a press release from the National Rifles Association of India (NRAI). Maharashtra's Abhidnya Ashok Patil took seventh place with 13 hits, while MP's Chinki Yadav, who had topped qualification with score of 586 (22x), finished eighth with nine hits. Earlier in qualification, Bhaker finished second with 584 (16x), while Arshdeep Kaur and Rahi Sarnobat were third and fourth with scores of 579 (20x) and 579 (18x).

Many from this group will be part of 2032, 2036 Olympics: Rani Rampal



SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

Former India captain Rani Rampal believes the country's women's Under-18 Asia Cup bronze medal-winning team has the potential to form the "core" of future Olympic squads, saying several players from the current batch could go on to represent the nation at the 2032 and 2036 Games. In her first major assignment as coach, the Indian hockey great guided the young side to a podium finish at the U-18 Women's Asia Cup in Japan, capping an encouraging campaign that showcased attacking flair, defensive resilience and immense promise. India scored a staggering 36 goals during the tournament, with striker Nousheen

Naz finishing as the top scorer with 12 goals from five matches. Geethasri Nammi struck six times, while captain Sweetie Kujur contributed five goals. "It was a very good tournament in terms of learning for the girls as well as for me as a coach. In this U-18 team, many players were only 14 and 15 years old," Rani told PTI after the team's arrival here on Monday. "There is a huge difference between sub-junior and senior-level hockey in terms of maturity, physicality and strength. I am sure many from this core group will feature in the 2032 and 2036 Olympics. This exposure will help them grow. The more mistakes they make, the more they learn." (PTI)

AITA welcomes inclusion of Dhamne, Adkar in TAGG scheme

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Rising stars Manas Dhamne and Vaishnavi Adkar were among four Indian tennis players inducted into the Government of India's Target Asian Games Group (TAGG) scheme, a move welcomed by All India Tennis Association (AITA). The other two players included in the scheme are men's singles player Dhakshinewar Suresh and doubles specialist Anirudh Chandrasekar. The four new inductees join 11 other Indian tennis players already supported under the TAGG scheme, including Sumit Nagal, Yuki Bhambri, Rutuja Bhosale, Arjun Kadhe, Rithvik Choudary Bollipalli, Vaidehi Chaudhari, Maya Rajeswaran, N Sriam Balaji, Saketh Myneni, Sahaja Yamalapalli and Shrivalli Bhamidipati.



Under the TAGG programme, selected athletes receive support through international competition exposure, coaching assistance, sports science services, physio-

therapy, strength and conditioning support, equipment assistance and other performance-related interventions. AITA said the inclusion of the quartet reflects the growing depth in Indian tennis and increasing emphasis on developing athletes capable of competing at highest levels. "The AITA looks forward to seeing athletes maximise the opportunities provided under TAGG and contribute to India's success at future Asian Games, Grand Slam events, Davis Cup, Billie Jean King Cup competitions" AITA Secretary General Sunder Iyer said.

FIFA-Infantino draw bipartisan skepticism ahead of Football World Cup 2026

STEVEN SLOAN/SEUNG MIN KIM
■ Washington

Dozens of mayors and other city leaders gathered in the ballroom of a Washington hotel on a snowy January morning this year, gripped by anger and anxiety about the federal government's increasingly aggressive immigration enforcement operation that included the killings of two US citizens in Minneapolis. And then FIFA President Gianni Infantino took the stage. "For the first time in 250 years of the history of the United States of America, well, you will not just be invaded, but you will be conquered," he said as the audience at the National Conference of Mayors largely reacted with silence. "You will be conquered by soccer," he added in an attempt to land the joke and get the crowd energised about the World Cup, which will be hosted jointly by the U.S., Mexico and Canada from

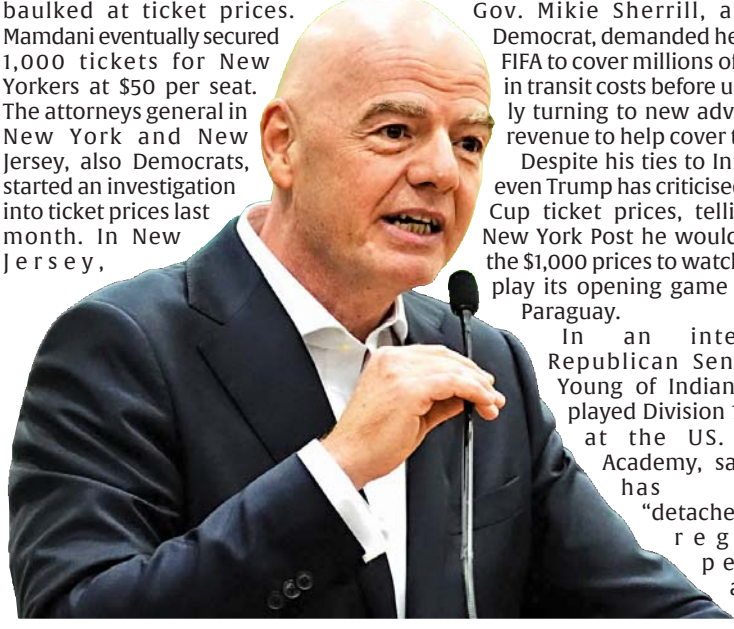
Thursday through July 19. Ahead of the tournament, Infantino has successfully cosied up to President Donald Trump, creating a peace prize that was awarded to him and frequently visiting the White House, including a stop last week, when he was photographed alongside the Republican president admiring changes outside the Oval Office. Infantino has struggled with virtually everyone else. In a deeply polarised country, few things unite elected leaders outside the White House quite like scepticism of Infantino and FIFA, the governing body for the world's most popular sport. It's a sentiment that cuts across the divide and spans from Washington to state capitals and city halls. Ticket prices attract bipartisan criticism: There are mayors like Zohran Mamdani of New York and Karen Bass of Los Angeles, Democrats who've

baulked at ticket prices. Mamdani eventually secured 1,000 tickets for New Yorkers at \$50 per seat. The attorneys general in New York and New Jersey, also Democrats, started an investigation into ticket prices last month. In New Jersey,

Gov. Mikie Sherrill, another Democrat, demanded help from FIFA to cover millions of dollars in transit costs before ultimately turning to new advertising revenue to help cover the gap. Despite his ties to Infantino, even Trump has criticised World Cup ticket prices, telling The New York Post he wouldn't pay the \$1,000 prices to watch the US play its opening game against Paraguay. In an interview, Republican Sen. Todd Young of Indiana, who played Division I soccer at the U.S. Naval Academy, said FIFA has been "detached from regular people around the

world." "It really is a cabal run by elites," Young added. "They really have had problems with corruption over the years, and one really does get the sense that they may overlook their singular mission, which is to help grow the sport, especially among young people around the world who wouldn't otherwise have the resources to access soccer." "Every good soccer fan who loves international football wishes Infantino would be a little less in the news and more promoting the game," Rep Rick Larsen, D-Washington, said in an interview. A FIFA representative didn't respond to a request for comment. FIFA's sceptics said they were still enthusiastic about the 48-team tournament. Some lawmakers said Infantino was navigating a challenging political environment in the US. Infantino is "doing the job he needs to do in terms of cultivating the Trump

administration," said Rep. Darin LaHood, R-Ill., the chair of the Congressional Soccer Caucus. The World Cup kicks off a series of events that are central to Trump's second-term effort to burnish his image and legacy through his association with high-profile sporting events. He'll hold a UFC bout on the South Lawn of the White House this month. It all culminates with the Olympics in Los Angeles in 2028, the final year of Trump's presidency. But the soccer tournament opens against the backdrop of an intensely divided political climate in the US - with Trump at the centre. Just 37% of US adults approve of the way Trump is handling the presidency, according to a May poll from The Associated Press-NORC Centre for Public Affairs Research. Still, Trump is intensifying efforts to put himself in middle of American life, particularly as country celebrates 250th anniversary of its independence. (AP)



India thrash Afghanistan as Manav Suthar shines

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ Mullanpur

Left-arm Manav Suthar's emergence as the flag-bearer of India's spin attack in the foreseeable future was the biggest gain for the hosts in their expectedly dominant innings and 300 runs victory over Afghanistan in the one-off Test here on Monday. After being bowled out for 152 in the first innings, courtesy a 6/33 from Suthar, Afghanistan fared much worse in the second essay, getting bundled out for 112 in 35.5 overs midway into the third day to hand India their biggest innings win.

Washington Sundar (4/36) did the star turn in the second innings while Kuldeep Yadav (3/30) also helped himself to some easy pickings. In 2018, India had thrashed the Afghans by an innings and 260 runs, but the visitors would take solace that they could stretch this Test into the third day.

The match belonged to Suthar, a left-arm orthodox spinner from Rajasthan's Sri Ganganagar. He became the 10th Indian bowler to take a five-for on debut with his overall haul of seven wickets (6/33 and 1/29), but more importantly, he answered the lingering question in the country's cricketing ecosystem: "Who will take over the baton from Ravindra Jadeja as and when he calls time?"

After the match against Afghanistan, Suthar showed all the requisite attributes to succeed at the highest level. The biggest among them is the consistency of landing the ball in the same spot.

Add the speed at which he bowls and the



number of revolutions that he imparts while putting his whole body behind each delivery, and Suthar is a complete package.

India has had bowlers who were wicket-takers on turners, but the 23-year-old has shown that he can be a match-winner on placid surfaces by extracting both turn and bounce. With Ravichandran Ashwin already retired and Jadeja in the twilight of his Test career, Suthar's emergence couldn't have happened at a better time. He will face a far bigger Test in Sri Lanka, where the quality of batting will be way better, but the Indian team management can think of slowly phasing Jadeja out by the end of this World Test Championship cycle. (PTI)



I learnt that consistency is everything in Test cricket: Suthar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mullanpur

Debutant left-arm spinner Manav Suthar said on Monday that his maiden Test appearance taught him that consistency and patience are the biggest virtues in the longest format, after starring in India's comprehensive innings-and-300-run victory over Afghanistan in the one-off match in Mullanpur. Named Player of the Match for his seven-wicket match haul, Suthar said repeatedly hitting the same areas was the secret behind his success on a surface

that offered plenty of assistance to the spinners.

"The biggest lesson is that consistency is everything. You have to keep bowling in the same area over and over again. I think that's the most important thing in Test cricket. It's a format that demands a lot of patience," Suthar said at the presentation ceremony.

"That's what I've learned, keep being patient, stick to your plans and keep hitting the right areas consistently," he said. The 23-year-old left-arm spinner said that representing India in Test cricket felt surreal.

"It was a very unreal feeling. It has been my dream from the very beginning to play for India and to play Test cricket. So it was an incredible moment for me and honestly felt quite unreal." Suthar said batting before bowling helped him understand the nature of the wicket, which in turn aided his bowling plans.

"Even when I went out to bat, I felt quite comfortable. As I settled in and faced a few deliveries, I realised there was a bit of assistance for the spinners on the wicket."

"Then, when I came on to bowl and delivered my first over, I got the same feeling. After that, my only focus was to keep using the right line, length and pace."

The spinner said he consciously relied on his stock ball in the initial phase before introducing subtle variations. "Initially, my focus was on understanding how the wicket was playing. That's why I wanted to rely on my stock delivery as much as possible."

"Once I understood that the wicket was a little slow and required some variation in pace, I started making those adjustments. But the main idea was always to make my stock ball as effective as possible."

Suthar also expressed pride at being entrusted with the second new ball during the match.

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ Mullanpur

Left-arm spinner Manav Suthar excelling on his Test debut is a testament to the robust structure that BCCI has created for talent identification, India batting coach Sitanshu Kotak said on Monday after the home team trounced Afghanistan inside three days here.

Kotak spoke after India's innings and 300 runs win, which was their biggest innings triumph.

Suthar was the standout performer, ending with a match haul of seven wickets, including six in the first innings.

Suthar's rise testament to BCCI's talent identification structure: Kotak

He landed the ball consistently on the middle and off-stumps and got the ball to turn at optimal speed.

"He (Suthar) really bowled well. He is a good prospect. For the past 2-3 years, Manav has been regularly playing for India A and India Emerging. This was a great opportunity for him, and he did well, too. In fact, he batted very well,



so that is actually very satisfying," Kotak said at the end of the match.

Kotak attributed Suthar's rise to BCCI's pathways structure, which identifies, nurtures and puts the talent in the fast lane. "I feel the BCCI structure helps, where you play so many matches before coming to the Test level. From the age-group (cricket),

Ranji Trophy, Emerging to India A, there are a lot of matches. It is a great exposure for all the players.

"And obviously, Manav is one of them who has been performing for three to four years. So, good luck to him," Kotak said. When asked to elaborate on how the team management zeroed in on the Rajasthan bowler ahead of Harsh Dubey, Kotak gave a detailed explanation. "See, in the last three years, Manav was part of one camp (at COE), which I conduct-

ed. He was part of the India Emerging team when we played in the Emerging Asia Cup or something," Kotak said.

"And then, for India A also, he was there in the Australia series. He was also there against England in Ahmedabad, where we played a three-match series. He was someone, the way he bowls, anybody would say he's very, very promising. He has been consistent, and he is very hardworking."

Kotak believes that one can see if

someone is an Indian prospect or not.

"To be very honest, since I saw him, I more or less knew that he would play for India. It depends on how every individual grows and how quickly they grow." "On why Manav played ahead of Harsh, that is obviously the head coach and captain's call. Harsh is there in the one-day squad, so I don't know, he might get an opportunity there," he said.

"He has done well in the IPL, and he has done well in the Ranji Trophy also. Obviously, only one can play, so Manav, probably, they must have thought, is the one for them to go with." (PTI)

Tamim Iqbal takes over as Bangladesh Cricket Board chief



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dhaka

Former Bangladesh captain Tamim Iqbal was elected as the President of his country's Cricket Board here, becoming the youngest to get the position that he will hold for four years.

The 37-year-old has already served as the head of the ad-hoc committee that he took over in April after Islam was found guilty of corruption in a probe. "There are a lot of things, loopholes, and if we all agree together (about constitutional reform) we will discuss them in the next AGM. This is not like a board of 12 or 13 people where one person says something and it is done."

"We have to deal with 1972 councillors. So they also have to agree. But for the betterment of Bangladesh cricket, if any constitutional changes are needed, we will definitely discuss and consider them," Tamim was quoted as saying by 'Cricbuzz' following the election on Sunday. The former batter, who played 70 Tests and 243 ODIs for his team in a career spanning 15 years, said he would need time to make structural changes in the Bangladesh Cricket Board. The BCB was in the spotlight for a high-voltage confrontation with India earlier this year after Mustafizur Rahman was omitted from the IPL despite landing a deal with the Kolkata Knight Riders.

Tamim was one of the voices within Bangladesh who had advised against a standoff with India.

"It is very new for me because I still have to mix with all these people. I may not know more than half of them. I met them for the first time. So give us some time, let us discuss, and then we will find out where improvements are needed," he said.

"I hope we can be as transparent as possible. Because I am sure I do not want any of my board members to do anything that makes us controversial. From my side and from the whole board's side, we will try to act with full honesty," he added. The election was held at the Sher-e-Bangla National Stadium. Tamim, who became the 21st president of the BCB, garnered 73 votes from 75 councillors.

We showed our naivety, there's plenty of work to be done: Richard Pybus

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ Mullanpur

Afghanistan head coach Richard Pybus conceded that his side's approach in the one-off Test against India was marked by considerable "naivety", attributing the crushing defeat to a lack of exposure and game time at the highest level of the format. This was Afghanistan's 12th Test in last eight years and the defeat by an innings and 300 runs against India was a humbling experience for the team.

Pybus, the journeyman English coach, spoke about the rustiness and how he intends to speak to the Afghanistan cricket's top brass about where Test cricket stands in terms of commitment quotient.

"So, you know, there are some structural questions. I will have some feedback for the board when I go back. But also, it's like, you know, what is our commitment to Test cricket?" a dejected Pybus said at the end of the match.

The lack of Test cricket will keep on hurting Afghanistan if there are such yawning gaps between two red ball games at the international cricket.

"Having coached a lot of first-class cricket, it's a little bit like coming out of pre-season and then you've got to get into the rhythm of playing long-format cricket," Pybus said. "So we were rusty,



we showed our naivety and there's plenty of work to be done," he was as honest as possible in his admission. Then came the oft-repeated topic of lack of exposure and a comparison with the country's white ball teams.



"You can play as much red-ball cricket at home domestically and, you know, there aren't that many first-class sides and it's not a long fixture list." Some of Afghanistan's biggest white-ball stars, including Rashid Khan, Noor Ahmed, and Allah Ghazanfar, don't play red-ball cricket and Pybus, without naming anyone, accepted that it is a problem. "A lot of white-ball stars who are genuine stars in world cricket are not playing first-class cricket, and that sometimes would not help younger guys. Every side historically, as it evolves, needs fixtures to play," Pybus said. (PTI)

Form of openers, bowling main areas of concern as India head into T20 WC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

For the second time in eight months, the Indian women's cricket team may well have to depend on individual brilliance to win an ICC title, considering their shortcomings in all departments.

The road to the path-breaking ODI World Cup triumph in November was full of bumps, but Jemimah Rodrigues carried the team on her shoulders to get their hands on the elusive trophy.

Not so long ago, India seemed to have most bases covered in the shortest format, but the back-to-back series loss in South Africa and England in the lead-up to the T20 showpiece has exposed the obvious chinks in the armour.

The form of openers Shafali Verma and Smriti Mandhana has been tepid of late, with the lower-order also not performing as per expectations. The team's designated power hitter, Richa Ghosh, doesn't have runs under her belt going into the World Cup opener against Pakistan on June 14.

The performance of veteran all-rounder Deepti Sharma, too, has left a lot to be desired both with bat and ball. As per former India captain Shantha Rangaswamy, India's main problems lie with the ball and not so much in the batting and fielding departments.

Her concerns are valid as England gunned down a competitive target of 181 comfortably against India to win the three-match series in the UK.

The absence of all-rounders Kashvee Gautam and Amanjot



Kaur has negatively impacted the balance of the squad. Traditionally, India has been spin-heavy with not many options in the pace department. Nandini Sharma has emerged as a rare positive in the pace attack, while left-arm spinner Shree Charani too has been impressive. Off-spinner Shreyanka Patil has done decently since her comeback, but overall, the bowling doesn't inspire a lot of confidence.

"The team has not done well of late, but they continue to have a positive body language. I am backing them to go all the way."

"Having said that, our bowling is not as good as our batting and fielding. We were always known

for a good bowling attack. We can't say that now," Shantha told PTI.

In all probability, 37-year-old Indian skipper Harmanpreet Kaur would be playing in her last World Cup. Her role in the middle order will be crucial if India is to consistently post totals above 180.

"I am a fan of Harmanpreet the batter. She remains as fit as ever. However, I always wanted her to focus more on her batting rather than captaincy. If she can find her rhythm, it makes the job much easier for others," added Shantha.

At top of the order, the lack of runs from Mandhana's bat causes plenty of concern as she is usually among the consistent performers.

Don't expect too much too soon: Kapil Dev on Vaibhav Sooryavanshi

ANKIT SHRESTHA ■ New Delhi

Cricket legend Kapil Dev has urged fans and experts to be patient with Vaibhav Sooryavanshi following his maiden India call-up, saying placing excessive expectations on the youngster at such an early stage of his career would be unfair. The 15-year-old sensation broke Sachin Tendulkar's record to become the youngest player selected for India's senior men's team. He was named in the squad for the T20I series against England and Ireland and has also been included in the contingent for the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan, later this year.

The 1983 World Cup-winning captain described the 15-year-old as a "special talent" but stressed that the transition to international cricket would require time and adjustment.

"He is a special talent; give him time,



but he definitely showed the talent that he has. I think he is unbelievable, but again, he will have to conduct himself (in the Indian team), keep himself fit, and a lot of other things are going to happen when you are part of the national team.

"How much he is focused, only he can answer, but to me, he is a special



talent," Kapil told PTI Videos on Monday. Kapil believes Sooryavanshi will soon learn the difference between playing for club and country.

"There's nothing wrong with giving

respect to the young kid, but expecting too much at this stage would be wrong; he has just been included in the team. He will understand that club cricket is totally different from playing for your

country, it's a different thought process, so give him time, don't start expecting too much, just give him time," he stressed. His former teammate and pacer Madan Lal has no doubt about the boy wonder emulating his Indian Premier League success on the international stage. "This is a very big moment for him because he is a 15-year-old player who has forced his selection. He has got this chance because of his good performance."

"I think he will definitely be able to do it because he has the talent in abundance. Why won't he be able to do it? He is also in good form."

"He has played throughout the tournament and performed consistently. He is only 15 years old and has already shown what he is capable of," Lal said.

Sooryavanshi has hampered the likes of Pat Cummins and Kagiso Rabada with gay abandon during IPL this year.